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DOMINIONS 6 KNOWLEDGE LIBRARY

# Middle Age Nation Compendium

Volume I: Arcoscephale, Marignon, and Pyrène.

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Progress Edition 27 companion reader  
29 August 2026

Unmodded 6.36 baseline. DE and Divinitus remain separately labelled.

# Contents

This first Middle Age volume contains the complete Arcoscephale, Marignon, and Pyrène dossiers from Book VII. It does not present the remaining Middle Age nations as finished.

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## DOCUMENT 1 OF 1

# Foundation Book VII: Nations

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## The Nation Dossier Method, Middle Age Arcoscephale, Marignon, and Pyrène

### What a nation dossier should do

A nation guide should do more than name strong units and recommend a research queue. It should explain how a nation turns its starting roster into a functioning state, how that state changes when research arrives, how its plans fail, and how to rebuild those plans when the ruleset changes.

This volume of the nation library does two jobs:

- establish a reproducible method for every later nation dossier;
- apply that method to Middle Age Arcoscephale, the Old Kingdom, Middle Age Marignon, Fiery Justice, and Middle Age Pyrène, Time of the Akelarre.

It offers a safe first route through the roster and opening, but it also follows the harder questions of mage probability, force packages, path access, counters, logistics, and opportunity cost. There is no single build detached from map, opponents, settings, and patch. The dossier instead presents several coherent strategic families and the conditions that favour each one.

### Edition note

Book I defines the common 6.36 live baseline and evidence terms. The dossiers' structured object comparisons remain pinned to their stated 6.35 snapshot. Unmodded rules, DE 2.16, Divinitus 1.15.3 DE, and the combined load order stay visibly separate. Book IX owns the general mod catalogue; [Book VII](#) applies it to individual nations.

### How to use this dossier

The one-page brief, roster, expansion plan, mage roles, research branches, army packages, and turn checklists form the practical core. Probability portfolios, communion failure analysis, access ladders, matchups, reserves, and controlled tests provide the expert layer. Each nation chapter begins again from its own ruleset and evidence label; advice from one dossier should not be carried into another merely because both are Middle Age nations.

## Part I: The Nation Dossier Method

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### What a complete nation guide must answer

A useful dossier answers twelve questions.

| Question                                                      | Required evidence                                                   |
|---------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|
| What is the nation trying to convert?                         | National summary, roster, magic, economy                            |
| What wins neutral expansion?                                  | Unit statistics, formations, repeated tests                         |
| What prevents an early defeat?                                | Neighbour analysis, reachable research, reserve plan                |
| What does each fort recruit?                                  | Commander costs, recruitment points, role demand                    |
| What does each mage random actually enable?                   | Exact random scheme and probability                                 |
| Which research creates deployable packages?                   | Spells, paths, gems, mage-turns, delivery                           |
| Which paths are native, bootstrapped, or Pretender-dependent? | Access ladder with every step named                                 |
| How does the nation fight different defence classes?          | Armour, numbers, elites, giants, ethereal, undead, magic resistance |
| How does it raid, defend, siege, and claim?                   | Movement, leadership, magic, siege strength, priests                |
| What information does it possess or lack?                     | Scouts, spies, scrying, remote spells, battle evidence              |
| Which Pretender family solves the actual constraint?          | Legal design, scales, timing, bless and ritual jobs                 |
| What changes under each mod?                                  | Source diff, load order, combined test                              |

If one answer is missing, the guide should say so. Concealing uncertainty creates a brittle strategy.

## The four layers of a nation

Every nation should be analysed in four layers.

| Layer    | Contents                                                 | Common mistake                                  |
|----------|----------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| Rules    | Roster, paths, costs, sites, spells, dominion, buildings | Repeating obsolete data                         |
| Capacity | What can be recruited, researched, forged, and delivered | Treating theoretical access as immediate access |
| Doctrine | How the capacities can be combined                       | Presenting one context-dependent plan as law    |
| Evidence | Tests, replays, probability, and source records          | Treating an anecdotal win as proof              |

The rules layer is descriptive. Capacity is conditional: an E2S1 mage does not automatically equal an E2S2 ritual caster; the necessary item, gems, laboratory, and forge turn must exist. Doctrine is comparative: one package is chosen because it fits an enemy, a deadline, and an economy. Evidence determines confidence.

## The national conversion chain

The central dossier model is:

```
scales and starting assets
-> expansion and borders
-> forts and recruitment
-> mage distribution
-> research and gems
-> battlefield or ritual packages
-> positional gains
-> siege, Throne claim, and victory
```

A nation can fail at any arrow. Strong troops may expand but consume so many resources that the second fort cannot recruit. Broad magic may remain a collection of low paths if no communion or

booster plan exists. A devastating battlefield spell may arrive without the troops, gems, or movement needed to exploit it. A winning army may lack siege or claim capacity.

Each nation chapter records both assets and conversions.

## The national identity statement

A national identity statement should be one paragraph, not a slogan. It should name:

- the reliable early force;
- the recruitment bottleneck;
- the magic engine;
- the information advantage;
- the main strategic transition;
- the principal vulnerabilities.

An identity statement is a starting hypothesis. It must be revised when a patch or mod changes one of those elements.

## Roster analysis by job

Units should first be grouped by job, then compared by statistics.

| Job        | Questions                                                                     |
|------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Screen     | How cheaply can it absorb missiles, charges, and first contact?               |
| Line       | What ordinary damage can it resist, and how long before fatigue defeats it?   |
| Damage     | What armour, size, defence, or resistance class can it kill?                  |
| Flank      | Can it reach exposed mages or force the enemy to deploy wider?                |
| Trampler   | What sizes can it trample, and how are morale and magic resistance protected? |
| Sacred     | Is the unit scarce, cap-only, resource-heavy, or massable?                    |
| Siege body | What wall damage, supply use, and opportunity cost does it impose?            |
| Raider     | Which Province Defence and local recruits can it beat reliably?               |
| Bodyguard  | What assassination, arrow, or flying threat does it prevent?                  |

"Elite" is not a job. "High protection" is not a complete evaluation. A high-protection unit with low combat speed, high encumbrance, and ordinary damage may be an excellent anvil and a poor pursuit force.

## Commander analysis by constrained turn

Commanders compete for recruitment capacity. Their gold cost is only one part of the decision.

For every commander, record:

- commander recruitment-point cost;
- fort and terrain restrictions;
- leadership types and limits;
- research;
- priest level;
- magic and randoms;

- strategic abilities;
- likely monthly orders;
- what is delayed when this commander is recruited.

A capital-only four-point mage has a different strategic cost from a one-point scout even if sufficient gold exists for both. Nation plans should budget fort-turns, capital-turns, and commander points as explicitly as gold.

## Magic access as a probability portfolio

Random paths are not a list of possible maxima. They are a distribution.

For every random mage, the dossier should record:

- fixed paths;
- each random roll and its probability;
- maximum natural paths;
- probability of each important threshold;
- mutually impossible combinations;
- expected recruits needed for a role;
- the effect of bad variance;
- what a Pretender or independent mage can replace.

If a required result occurs with probability  $(p)$ , the probability of seeing at least one result after  $(n)$  independent recruits is:

$$P(\text{at least one}) = 1 - (1 - p)^n$$

The expected count  $(1/p)$  is not a guarantee. A one-in-eight specialist has about a 65.6% chance to appear within eight recruits, not certainty. It takes twenty-three recruits to exceed a 95% chance:

$$1 - (7/8)^{23} \approx 95.4\%$$

This distinction matters when the first war arrives before the desired random.

## Native, bootstrapped, and imported access

Every path claim belongs in one of four classes.

| Class          | Meaning                                                                          |
|----------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Native         | A normal national recruit can perform the job without external help              |
| Boosted native | A national recruit can perform it with named items or self-buffs                 |
| Bootstrapped   | An earlier summon, transformation, empowerment, or national event creates access |
| Imported       | A Pretender, hero, independent, mercenary, Throne, site, or ally provides access |

The access ledger must name every bridge. "Arcoscephale can cast a Death ritual" is incomplete if it actually means "a rare Nature hero forges or casts into a summon chain that eventually produces Death."

## Research as response trees

A fixed research queue assumes the enemy and map will cooperate. A response tree has:

- a trunk of broadly useful early research;
- branches for observed threats;
- conversion nodes where research becomes a fieldable package;
- rejoin points so emergency research does not permanently destroy the long plan.

Every node should specify:

- school and level;
- spell or item obtained;
- eligible caster;
- required communion, booster, or self-buff;
- gem load;
- troop or target interaction;
- operational delivery;
- counters;
- what the research delays.

## Army packages, not spell lists

An army package is:

troops + commanders + mages + scripts + gems + formation  
+ movement route + retreat route + replacement plan

A spell becomes strategy only when the nation can put the correct caster, protection, gems, and targets in the same battle.

Each package should have:

- purpose: what defence or target it defeats;
- minimum core: the smallest robust version;
- scaling rule: what to add as the enemy grows;
- failure branch: what happens if the script is interrupted;
- counter warning: the most economical answer available to the enemy;
- replacement cost: how quickly the nation can field another.

## Matchup classification

Nation-versus-nation memorisation becomes obsolete quickly. Defence classes are more durable.

| Enemy class                | Questions                                                                |
|----------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Massed light troops        | Can the nation kill squares faster than it is surrounded?                |
| Heavy armour               | Is damage high enough, or is armour destruction available?               |
| High defence and glamour   | Are attack buffs, area effects, or sight effects available?              |
| Giants and elite sacreds   | Can control, fatigue, armour-negating damage, or mass be delivered?      |
| Undead and demons          | Are priests, magic weapons, banishment, morale, and resistance adequate? |
| Flyers and cavalry         | Is the rear protected and the line deep enough?                          |
| Tramplers                  | Can size, body-blocking, control, and morale attacks stop them?          |
| Battle-mage mass           | Can the nation disperse, interrupt, resist, or strike first?             |
| Thugs and supercombatants  | Can the chassis be controlled, exhausted, penetrated, or ignored?        |
| Remote and stealth warfare | Are domes, patrols, redundant labs, and reserves in place?               |

Specific opponents can then be placed into one or more classes.

## Pretender families

A dossier should present families, not copied designs:

- awake expansion: buys early territory and deterrence;
- dormant intervention: appears for the first war or path bridge;
- imprisoned scales: maximises the recruitable state;
- bless support: improves a sacred unit that can be recruited in relevant numbers;
- ritual bridge: supplies paths the national roster cannot reach;
- hybrid: deliberately performs two of these jobs at a real cost to each.

Every proposed build must pass five audits:

- 1 legality in the exact version and mod order;
- 2 expansion or survival job;
- 3 scales and recruitment compatibility;
- 4 mid-game job on awakening;
- 5 unique late-game access that cannot be bought more cheaply elsewhere.

## Verification standard

Nation claims are verified in this order:

- 1 official manual or current official data;
- 2 current structured object data;
- 3 supplied mod source;
- 4 controlled game test;
- 5 detailed community evidence;
- 6 strategic inference.

The source hierarchy does not make community strategy unimportant. It prevents strategic experience from being confused with engine definition.

## Minimum controlled-test suite

Every nation eventually receives:

- three or more turn-12 expansion runs for each serious Pretender family;
- controlled battles against the main independent types;
- random-mage sampling large enough to detect transcription errors;
- communion fatigue and script tests;
- a research timing test with realistic infrastructure;
- siege and storm tests;
- representative matchups against armour, elites, undead, flyers, tramlers, and magic;
- modded repetitions under each supported load order;
- a save, turn number, settings record, result table, and replay note.

Until those tests are recorded, precise party sizes and timing claims remain hypotheses.

# Part II: Middle Age Arcoscephale, the Old Kingdom

## The one-page national brief

Middle Age Arcoscephale is a human combined-arms nation whose ordinary military is old-fashioned but broad: inexpensive formation infantry, armoured spear lines, chariots, elephants, and a small capital sacred. Its strategic engine is a network of recruit-anywhere Mystics backed by capital Astrologers, priestess-healers, and automatic scrying inside friendly dominion.

The nation converts gold into versatile S1 elemental mages, those mages into communions or independent specialist casters, and research into an adaptable battlefield. It is strongest when intelligence identifies the defence to defeat before the army is scripted. It is weakest when expensive human mages are caught unprotected, when tramlers are exposed to morale or magic-resistance attacks, when heavy infantry is exhausted, or when random-path variance prevents a required specialist from arriving on time.

## National profile

| Feature            | Unmodded Dominions 6.35                                  |
|--------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| Race               | Humans                                                   |
| Military           | Heavy spear infantry, chariots, elephants                |
| Recruitable magic  | Astral, Fire, Water, Earth; some Nature                  |
| Priests            | H1 and H2 priestess-healers                              |
| Dominion           | Accurate automatic military reports inside dominion      |
| Scale limit        | Order limit +1                                           |
| Forts              | Standard                                                 |
| Laboratories       | 300 gold                                                 |
| Capital income     | 1 Nature gem and 4 Astral pearls per month               |
| Central constraint | Gold- and mage-turn-intensive magical state              |
| Central advantage  | Information plus highly adaptable recruit-anywhere magic |

## Lore and strategic meaning

The Old Kingdom is intentionally archaic. Its armies retain cumbersome armour, long spears, chariots, and war elephants while ancient Astrologers return to guide the realm. This is not only flavour. The roster juxtaposes slow, reliable formation troops with volatile tramlers, while the mage corps juxtaposes broad low-level access with capital astral depth.

Three strategic themes follow.

First, knowledge precedes commitment. Automatic scrying inside dominion and Astrologers who read the heavens support a nation that should know what is approaching before choosing a script.

Second, the old army needs magical renewal. The troops can expand and hold ground, but armour, fatigue, morale, large targets, and elite opposition eventually require tailored magic.



Third, restoration is cumulative. Arcoscephale becomes stronger as forts produce Mystics, research broadens, boosters accumulate, and communions scale. Losing a mage core or capital does more than remove units; it breaks the conversion chain.

## National special features

### Automatic dominion scrying

Official: provinces inside Arcoscephale's dominion receive accurate automatic military reports. Current structured data also identifies this scrying as capable of revealing glamourised units, and disciple partners receive the information.

This is a strategic advantage, not omniscience.

It helps with:

- army size and composition near the interior;
- early warning against ordinary movement;
- more informed deployment of elephants, communions, and counters;
- identifying when a border force has split;
- tracking glamourised forces that ordinary reports may conceal.

It does not replace:

- scouts beyond dominion;
- spies for income, unrest, Province Defence, and deeper provincial information;
- battle replays for scripts, gems, and exact spell use;
- patrols against stealth;
- caution against magic movement, assassinations, remote attacks, and simultaneous orders.

The correct doctrine is a layered network:

- 1 scouts beyond the border;
- 2 dominion scrying across owned approaches;
- 3 reserve mages at central laboratories;
- 4 battle reports converted into response scripts.

### Order limit +1

The nation can take one more step toward Order than an ordinary nation. This is not an instruction to maximise Order in every design. It is an option to support:

- expensive Mystics and Astrologers;
- fort and laboratory construction;
- elephant and chariot recruitment;
- larger mundane armies;
- reduced dependence on risky event income.

The scale must be evaluated against the Pretender family and opportunity cost. A high-Order scales design and an awake expander solve different problems.

### Healing

Hiereiai have Healing 1. Archousai have Healing 3.

Official rule: a healer automatically attempts to cure a number of afflictions up to the value of the ability in the same province each turn. Healing is a provincial capacity. It does not guarantee that the exact desired affliction on the exact desired unit disappears immediately.

Healing improves the expected service life of:

- expensive commanders;
- Astrologers;
- battle-wounded Mystics;
- a combat Pretender that can be healed;
- surviving elephants and sacreds;
- thugs and summoned commanders without healing restrictions.

Healing does not make reckless attacks efficient. Dead units cannot be healed, some beings have special restrictions, and cursed-item afflictions require removal of the item first.

## Recrutable commander roster

The following table is the official revision-2 unmodded roster. Rec is commander recruitment-point cost.

| Commander           | Gold | Res | Rec | Principal attributes and role                                       |
|---------------------|------|-----|-----|---------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Scout               | 35   | 5   | 1   | Stealth 50, Forest and Mountain Survival; forward intelligence      |
| Mounted Commander   | 70   | 9   | 1   | Leadership 75, Map Move 16; fast transport for compatible forces    |
| Hypaspist Commander | 95   | 25  | 1   | Leadership 100, Protection 15, Defence 14; armoured line commander  |
| Hoplite Commander   | 105  | 31  | 1   | Leadership 100, Protection 18; slow heavy commander                 |
| Strategos           | 150  | 30  | 2   | Leadership 150, Morale 15; large formations and army command        |
| Hiereia             | 155  | 1   | 2   | N1H1, Sacred, Healing 1; recrutable outside forts                   |
| Mystic              | 190  | 1   | 2   | S1 plus elemental/astral randoms, Research +1; main national mage   |
| Archousa            | 235  | 1   | 2   | N1H2, Sacred, Healing 3, Leadership 50                              |
| Astrologer          | 270  | 1   | 4   | Capital only, S3 plus randoms, Fortune Teller 10; astral specialist |

## Recruitment doctrine

No commander is "free" merely because the treasury can pay for it.

- A Scout competes with a leader or mage for the local commander queue.
- A Strategos is valuable when leadership quality and army size justify the extra recruitment cost.
- A Hiereia can be recruited outside forts, preserving fort mage production while extending temples, healing, supplies, and H1 support.
- A Mystic is normally the default fort investment because it produces research and future battlefield flexibility.
- An Archousa is a healing and H2 capacity purchase, not a generic researcher.
- An Astrologer consumes scarce capital recruitment capacity and should have a defined astral job.

The recurring question is:

Which missing capacity causes the next failure: intelligence, transport, leadership, religion, healing, research, or high Astral?

## Recrutable troop roster

The official revision-2 values below describe the unmodded units. Mounts and coriders are separate combat entities where applicable.

| Unit            | Gold | Res | Rec | Protecti<br>on | Morale | Combat /<br>map move | Primary role                                  |
|-----------------|------|-----|-----|----------------|--------|----------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| Slinger         | 7    | 2   | 3   | 5              | 7      | 12 / 14              | Cheap ranged harassment and screening         |
| Cardaces        | 10   | 8   | 9   | 9              | 10     | 11 / 16              | Cheap formation infantry                      |
| Peltast         | 10   | 5   | 9   | 5              | 10     | 11 / 16              | Mobile spear and javelin screen               |
| Hoplite         | 13   | 31  | 16  | 18             | 11     | 7 / 14               | Resource-heavy armoured anvil                 |
| Hypaspist       | 16   | 25  | 23  | 15             | 13     | 10 / 16              | Higher-defence, higher-morale heavy infantry  |
| Charioteer      | 40   | 7   | 9   | 9              | 10     | Rider 12 / 16        | Chariot trampling and mobile missile pressure |
| Elephant Rider  | 100  | 3   | 9   | 5              | 8      | Rider 12 / 16        | War-elephant trampling with two archers       |
| Heart Companion | 20   | 31  | 23  | 18             | 13     | 8 / 14               | Capital-only sacred heavy spear infantry      |

## Mounts

| Mount        | HP | Prot | MR | Morale | Combat / map<br>move | Role and risk                                                                         |
|--------------|----|------|----|--------|----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Riding Horse | 18 | 3    | 5  | 7      | 26 / 22              | Gives the Mounted Commander strategic and tactical speed                              |
| Chariot      | 20 | 3    | 5  | 9      | 20 / 20              | Trampling platform; vulnerable if stopped or controlled                               |
| War Elephant | 64 | 11   | 6  | 9      | 18 / 22              | Large trampler; powerful against smaller bodies, vulnerable to MR and morale pressure |

## Troop roles and comparisons

### Slingers

Slingers are cheap bodies and ranged nuisance fire. Their morale, protection, attack, and defence are poor. They are useful when:

- an inexpensive screen protects a more valuable line;
- mass missiles can punish unshielded or low-protection enemies;
- recruitment resources are scarce;
- siege bodies are urgently required.

They should not be treated as a reliable melee line. A routed slinger mass can contribute to wider morale problems.

## Cardaces

Cardaces are the economical formation body. Protection 9 and Defence 13 are respectable for ten gold and eight resources, but their damage remains that of ordinary human spear infantry.

Use them to:

- add square density and bodies;
- hold ordinary light troops;
- screen elephants or mages;
- fill lines when resources cannot support Hoplites;
- absorb attacks whose damage would waste expensive armour anyway.

Do not ask Cardaces to solve high protection, giants, or elite sacreds without magic.

## Peltasts

Peltasts exchange armour for javelins and low resource cost. They support early contact by throwing before melee and are less resource-constrained than the heavy line.

They are preferable when:

- the target is lightly protected;
- mobility and replacement matter;
- a sacrificial screen is needed;
- a province has gold but poor resources.

They are vulnerable to sustained missiles and decisive melee contact.

## Hoplites

Hoplites bring Protection 18 and long spears at only thirteen gold, but cost thirty-one resources and carry Encumbrance 8, Combat Speed 7, and Map Move 14.

Their favourable fight is a direct clash against ordinary, low- or moderate-damage infantry that must spend time cutting through armour. Their unfavourable fight includes:

- armour-negating or armour-piercing attacks;
- high-strength giants;
- armour destruction;
- prolonged fatigue environments;
- enemies that refuse the front and reach the mages;
- operational races where Map Move 14 is too slow.

Hoplites are an anvil. They need a hammer or a magical answer.

## Hypaspists

Hypaspists cost more gold and recruitment points than Hoplites but save six resources, gain Defence 13, Morale 13, Combat Speed 10, and Map Move 16 while retaining Protection 15.

They are generally better when:

- enemy damage already threatens to penetrate Protection 18;
- defence, morale, and mobility matter more than three protection;
- the army must keep pace with faster elements;
- gold is available but capital or local resources are constrained.

Hoplites are better at absorbing repeated ordinary hits. Hypaspists are a more flexible high-quality line. The choice should be made against an enemy damage profile and the province's resource economy, not by declaring one universally superior.

## Chariots

The chariot package supplies mobility, a trampling mount, and a corider archer. It threatens flanks and lighter units but is less decisive than the elephant against dense small bodies.

Chariots benefit from:

- a screen that prevents premature pinning;
- flank deployment;
- targets lacking large body-blockers;
- magic that improves survival or disrupts the enemy line.

They suffer when:

- surrounded after the charge;
- confronted by large units;
- controlled by magic;
- committed into weapons and buffs designed to punish mounts.

## War elephants

The elephant is Arcoscephale's most dramatic early force and its easiest trap.

Its 64 HP, Protection 11, Size, Combat Speed 18, Map Move 22, and trample can collapse ordinary human formations. The rider and two elephant archers add bodies and attacks, but the elephant's MR 6 and Morale 9 create explicit counter surfaces.

Use elephants as a package:

- a disciplined line or screen absorbs lances and delays contact;
- elephants begin behind or beside the screen rather than alone in front;
- leadership and standards support morale where available;
- the target has been scouted for size, anti-large damage, fear, paralysis, and MR-negates effects;
- a retreat route exists;
- the number committed is large enough to decide contact but not so large that one panic destroys the treasury.

Avoid treating elephants as an answer to:

- giants and other large bodies that cannot be trampled efficiently;
- high-defence elite troops that stop and surround them;
- concentrated fear or morale attacks;
- cheap MR-negates control or killing;
- poison, fatigue, and effects that exploit a large valuable target;
- narrow deployment where they cannot reach useful targets.

## Heart Companions

Heart Companions are capital-only, sacred, heavily armoured spear infantry. They are individually better than Hoplites, but remain Map Move 14 and consume scarce capital resources.

Their scarcity changes bless economics. A bless that exists only to improve a slow, capital-only sacred must be compared with:

- more scales for the entire economy;
- an awake expander;
- missing Death, Air, Glamour, or Blood access;
- a combat or ritual Pretender.

A light incidental bless can add value. A major bless needs a campaign plan that proves the capital can recruit enough Companions without delaying other essential forces.

## Formation doctrine

Arcoscephale's infantry benefits from formation-fighter density, but density has two faces.

It improves:

- concentration of melee attacks;
- the number of armoured bodies holding a frontage;
- the ability to protect mages behind a compact line;
- efficient buff coverage.

It increases exposure to:

- area damage;
- fatigue clouds;
- battlefield-wide debuffs;
- trampling if the enemy is large enough;
- mass routing when a dense formation loses many units quickly.

The default army should not be one dense block. It needs separate functional elements:

- a central anvil;
- one or two flank or trample groups;
- a rear guard against flyers and attack-rear orders;
- mages separated enough to reduce common-area losses;
- spare commanders so one casualty does not strand the army.

## Part III: The Mage State

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### Why the Mystic defines the nation

The Mystic is the repeatable national engine:

- recruitable in any fort;
- guaranteed Astral 1;
- one guaranteed random from Fire, Water, Earth, or Astral;
- an independent 50% Fire random;
- an independent 50% Water random;
- an independent 50% Earth random;
- Research +1;
- able to enter Astral communions;
- capable of independent low-level magic even when no communion is appropriate.

The important word is independent. The three 50% rolls are separate from the guaranteed four-path random and from each other.

## Mystic random structure

Let:

- $\backslash(R\backslash)$  be one guaranteed uniform roll among F, W, E, and S;
- $\backslash(F\_b\backslash)$ ,  $\backslash(W\_b\backslash)$ , and  $\backslash(E\_b\backslash)$  be independent 50% bonus rolls.

The final paths are:

```
S1
+ one level from R
+ F1 if Fb succeeds
+ W1 if Wb succeeds
+ E1 if Eb succeeds
```

There are thirty-two equally likely combinations before any other game effects: four values of  $\backslash(R\backslash)$  multiplied by eight combinations of the three binary bonus rolls.

## Mystic threshold probabilities

| Result                           | Probability | Interpretation                              |
|----------------------------------|-------------|---------------------------------------------|
| F0 / W0 / E0                     | 37.5% each  | No level in that element                    |
| F1 / W1 / E1 exactly             | 50% each    | Useful low-level elemental caster           |
| F2 / W2 / E2                     | 12.5% each  | One-in-eight natural specialist             |
| S1 exactly                       | 75%         | Ordinary communion-capable Mystic           |
| S2                               | 25%         | Stronger Astral caster or master            |
| Any named element at 1+          | 62.5%       | Five in eight                               |
| Any named pair of elements at 1+ | 37.5%       | Example: F1+ and E1+                        |
| F, W, and E all at 1+            | 21.875%     | Seven in thirty-two                         |
| Two elemental paths at level 2   | 0%          | Mutually impossible from this random scheme |
| E2 and S2                        | 0%          | Both require the single guaranteed roll     |

The last two rows are strategically important. A Mystic can be broad, but the same guaranteed roll cannot create two doubled paths. Plans requiring E2S2 or F2E2 need boosters, empowerment, a Pretender, a hero, or another access source.

## Probability of obtaining a specialist

For a one-in-eight F2, W2, or E2 Mystic:

| Recruits | Chance of at least one |
|----------|------------------------|
| 1        | 12.5%                  |
| 4        | 41.4%                  |
| 8        | 65.6%                  |
| 12       | 79.9%                  |
| 16       | 88.2%                  |
| 23       | 95.4%                  |

Derived: the table assumes independent recruitment rolls and uses  $\backslash(1-(7/8)^n\backslash)$ .

This produces a recruitment rule:

A one-in-eight random is a portfolio capability, not a deadline-safe capability.

If a war plan requires E2 by a fixed turn, build redundancy, recruit from multiple forts, or provide another route.

## Mystic role classification

Rename or otherwise record Mystics when recruited. A practical classification is:

| Tag        | Minimum path    | Principal jobs                                                             |
|------------|-----------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| S2         | S2              | Astral master, penetration and Astral scaling                              |
| F2         | F2              | Fire specialist, Fire self-buff route, high-damage evocation               |
| W2         | W2              | Water specialist, cold damage, Water buffs, elemental summons              |
| E2         | E2              | Earth specialist, protection, armour destruction, forging and Dragon Teeth |
| FWE        | F1W1E1          | Broad point buffs, site search, cross-path utility                         |
| FE         | F1E1+           | Fire/Earth cross-path and forging candidate                                |
| WE         | W1E1+           | Water/Earth cross-path and protection/control candidate                    |
| FW         | F1W1+           | Elemental resistance and mixed evocation candidate                         |
| S1 utility | No doubled path | Communion slave, research, low-level Astral and random-specific support    |

This is not a permanent caste system. A war can change priorities. The point is to prevent an E2 specialist from spending twenty turns as an anonymous researcher and then being unavailable when armour destruction is required.

## The Astrologer

The capital-only Astrologer has:

- fixed S3;
- one guaranteed random among F, W, E, and S;
- a further 10% random among F, W, E, and S;
- Fortune Teller 10;
- commander recruitment cost 4;
- Research 13 in the current structured data;
- high magical leadership.

### Astrologer probability

Assuming the 10% roll independently chooses one of the four listed paths:

| Astral result | Probability |
|---------------|-------------|
| S3            | 73.125%     |
| S4            | 26.25%      |
| S5            | 0.625%      |
| S4 or higher  | 26.875%     |



For any one element:

| Elemental result | Probability |
|------------------|-------------|
| No level         | 73.125%     |
| Level 1          | 26.25%      |
| Level 2          | 0.625%      |

Derived: these values include the rare 10% random instead of rounding the unit to "one in four S4."

## Astrologer roles

Astrologers are recruited for jobs that justify capital scarcity:

- reliable S3 master casting;
- S4 or rare S5 ritual and remote-magic thresholds;
- high-Astral penetration;
- a capital communion anchor;
- Fortune Teller concentration;
- eventual high-end Astral rituals and battlefield magic;
- an elemental random that opens a specific Astral cross-path.

An Astrologer should not automatically replace a Mystic as a generic researcher. The capital turn, gold, and recruitment points are the real comparison.

## Priestess-healers

### Hiereia

The Hiereia is N1H1, Healing 1, sacred, and recruitable outside forts.

Her roles include:

- building temples without consuming a fort mage turn;
- blessing sacreds;
- Sermon of Courage and other low-priest support;
- low Nature support;
- provincial healing;
- supply assistance;
- accompanying expansion or siege forces where one affliction recovered matters.

Outside-fort recruitment is a state-building advantage. Provinces without forts can produce religious infrastructure and healing while the forts continue producing Mystics.

### Archousa

The unmodded Archousa is N1H2 with Healing 3 and Leadership 50.

Her roles include:

- stronger healing concentration;
- H2 battle and ritual duties;
- leading a modest army while providing priest support;
- protecting the long-term value of expensive units and commanders.

She is not a substitute for broad Nature magic. Unmodded Arcoscephale's normal recruitable Nature ceiling is N1.

## Recruitment portfolios

### The research-first portfolio

Use when:

- borders are stable;
- the mundane army can deter a rush;
- no urgent H2 or healing deficit exists;
- an early research breakpoint creates the next advantage.

Default:

- most new forts recruit Mystics;
- capital alternates Astrologers and whatever national need is genuinely scarce;
- Hierieiai come from non-fort provinces;
- scouts are scheduled rather than forgotten.

Risk:

- too little mundane leadership;
- mages accumulated in one vulnerable laboratory;
- no reserve army;
- specialist variance arriving late.

### The healing-and-expander portfolio

Use with an awake or dormant combat Pretender and expensive surviving troops.

Add:

- one or more Archousai at recovery hubs;
- Hierieiai following army groups;
- a safe path from battlefield to healing province;
- explicit checks for beings or afflictions that cannot be healed normally.

Risk:

- buying more healing than the casualty pattern warrants;
- delaying the research or Astral depth that prevents the next wounds.

### The communion portfolio

Use when the first war requires path elevation.

Recruit:

- enough Mystics to separate slaves, masters, independent casters, and research;
- S2 or desired elemental masters;
- reserve slaves;
- ordinary leaders and screens that keep mages alive.

Risk:

- every master is counted but slaves are treated as expendable;

- slaves are also required for independent spells;
- shared self-buffs or fatigue kill the slave line;
- one battlefield clear destroys years of research investment.

The dispersed-reserve portfolio

Use against remote attacks, flyers, raiders, assassins, or fast fronts.

Maintain:

- small mage cells in several laboratories;
- spare pearls and elemental gems at operational hubs;
- scouts on approach routes;
- a mobile ordinary reserve;
- a protected capital core.

Risk:

- insufficient concentration for the decisive battle;
- gems and items stranded in isolated labs;
- scattered mages defeated in detail.

Part IV: Unmodded Magic Access

Native access summary

| Path    | Repeatable native ceiling | Main source                    | Important limitation                                      |
|---------|---------------------------|--------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| Fire    | F2                        | One-in-eight Mystic            | No native high Fire without communion or boosters         |
| Air     | None                      | Hero only at A1                | Normal roster cannot use Air                              |
| Water   | W2                        | One-in-eight Mystic            | High Water requires communion or access chain             |
| Earth   | E2                        | One-in-eight Mystic            | E2 and S2 do not occur on the same Mystic                 |
| Astral  | S4 common peak; rare S5   | Astrologer                     | Capital-only high Astral                                  |
| Death   | None                      | Summons, hero/Pretender routes | Several national rituals are inaccessible initially       |
| Nature  | N1                        | Hiereia and Archousa           | N3 hero is chance-dependent                               |
| Glamour | None                      | Summon or imported route       | No normal national access                                 |
| Blood   | None                      | Deep summon or imported route  | No normal Blood economy                                   |
| Holy    | H2                        | Archousa                       | H3 normally requires prophet/Pretender or imported access |

"Ceiling" here means a recruitable unit before boosters, empowerment, heroes, or communions. It does not mean that every spell at that level is strategically available; school, gems, range, and battlefield conditions still apply.

## Native battlefield strengths

### Astral

Astral is the stable spine:

- every Mystic can join a communion;
- S2 Mystics and S3+ Astrologers can serve as stronger masters;
- low-level Astral offers ethereal, luck, fatigue, mind, and resistance tools;
- high Astral creates remote and battlefield threats;
- capital pearl income supports early Astral use.

Astral also creates vulnerabilities:

- enemy Astral mages can threaten Magic Duel dynamics;
- communion clusters attract area attacks;
- pearls have competing uses in combat, forging, remote magic, and legendary rituals;
- an Astral plan without penetration can fail against high MR.

### Fire

Fire supplies direct damage and morale pressure. F2 Mystics are natural specialists; F1 Mystics can reach higher levels through a communion or self-buff where available.

Fire is strongest against:

- dense ordinary troops;
- cold-aligned or fire-vulnerable targets;
- formations whose protection is less relevant to the chosen spell.

It is weaker against:

- fire resistance;
- dispersed targets;
- friendly formations too close to inaccurate area fire;
- battles where fatigue and gem use outrun protection.

### Water

Water supplies cold damage, control, quickness and resistance effects, and elemental summons. W2 specialists are one in eight; W1 is common enough to support mixed packages.

Water is especially valuable when:

- the enemy lacks Cold Resistance;
- control and slowing matter more than raw kills;
- a Water/Earth Mystic can combine defensive and fatigue tools;
- summoned elementals can exploit enemy size or formation.

### Earth

Earth renews Arcoscephale's old infantry:

- protection;
- strength;
- armour destruction;
- battlefield control;

- reinvigoration and path elevation;
- constructs and national summons;
- forging.

E2 specialists are among the most important randoms because they can use national Sow Dragon Teeth without ritual access problems and can anchor Earth communions. Earth still does not solve every high-protection fight: the chosen package must specify whether it raises friendly durability, lowers enemy armour, deals high damage, or controls movement.

## Nature

N1 is support, not broad Nature dominance. It provides selected protection, entanglement, poison-related, healing, supply, and small-summon options as research permits.

Without a hero, Pretender, independent, empowerment, or summon chain, the nation does not naturally reach the powerful N3-N5 ritual tier. A guide that assumes easy high Nature is using another age, a mod, or an unrecorded access source.

## Communions

### Why Arcoscephale uses them

Mystics combine guaranteed S1 with heterogeneous elements. A communion:

- raises each master's known paths according to the number of slaves;
- distributes spell fatigue across participants;
- lets low elemental randoms reach battlefield thresholds;
- makes a roster of modest mages behave like a high-path school.

The official level thresholds are:

| Slaves | Master bonus |
|--------|--------------|
| 2      | +1           |
| 4      | +2           |
| 8      | +3           |
| 16     | +4           |
| 32     | +5           |

The bonus applies only to paths the master already knows.

### The smallest useful communion

Two slaves are enough to raise paths by one. This can turn:

- F2 into F3;
- W2 into W3;
- E2 into E3;
- S2 into S3;
- an Astrologer S3 into S4.

The small communion is efficient for a limited script, but brittle:

- one slave loss can remove the bonus;

- fatigue per slave is higher;
- an overambitious master script can collapse it;
- the master may choose an unintended expensive spell after scripted orders.

## Four- and eight-slave communions

Four slaves provide +2 and are the first general-purpose threshold for turning common F1/W1/E1 Mystics into level 3 casters.

Eight slaves provide +3 and support high-end battlefield effects, but create a large concentration of expensive mages. The cost includes:

- eight researchers leaving laboratories;
- pearls or scripting needed to establish the communion;
- bodyguards and formation space;
- fatigue management;
- risk of battlefield-wide or rear attacks;
- the loss of those mages if the army is trapped.

## Master selection

Choose masters by spell package:

- F2 master for Fire;
- W2 master for Water;
- E2 master for Earth;
- S2 Mystic or S3+ Astrologer for Astral;
- cross-path Mystic when the spell or shared buff genuinely requires it.

Avoid adding masters merely because they can join. Every additional master:

- increases total fatigue placed into the slave pool;
- expands spell-selection variance after scripts;
- raises the value of the target presented to the enemy.

## Slave selection

The cheapest-looking S1 Mystic may still carry a valuable cross-path. Slave selection should preserve:

- rare E2, W2, and F2 specialists;
- S2 masters;
- cross-paths needed for forging or point buffs;
- battlefield-independent casters.

If every Mystic costs the same, "slave" is a temporary assignment, not a low-value unit type.

## Fatigue failure

Official communion fatigue depends on:

- the spell's fatigue cost;
- the number of participants;
- the slave's relevant effective path compared with the master's;
- bonuses and effects included in effective skill;
- the continued number of living slaves.

The dangerous cascade is:

slave becomes exhausted  
 -> slave stops contributing or dies  
 -> remaining slaves receive more fatigue  
 -> master bonus can fall below a threshold  
 -> later spells become more expensive or illegal  
 -> communion collapses

The package must be tested with the actual master scripts, gems, self-buffs, enemy pressure, and expected battle length.

## When not to use a communion

Communions are not mandatory.

Independent casting is often better when:

- many Mystics can each cast a useful low-level spell;
- the spell does not need path elevation;
- the enemy can punish a mage cluster;
- the battle is small;
- slaves would cost more mage-turns than the target is worth;
- one pearl per independent caster produces more total useful actions;
- the desired mix of spells is easier to control without shared fatigue.

Community discussion of MA Arcoscephale correctly highlights this tradeoff: a Mystic assigned as a slave is not a cheap acolyte; it is a 190-gold researcher and possible specialist that no longer casts independently.

## National spells and rituals

The official unmodded national list contains one battlefield summon and seven rituals.

| Spell or ritual              | School         | Requirement | Cost           | Result                         | Native access               |
|------------------------------|----------------|-------------|----------------|--------------------------------|-----------------------------|
| Sow Dragon Teeth             | Enchantment 6  | E2          | 1 Earth gem    | 10 Spartae in battle           | Yes: E2 Mystic              |
| Forge Brass Bull             | Construction 6 | F3E3        | 25 Fire gems   | 1 Khalkotaurus                 | Not on an unboosted recruit |
| Summon Hound of Twilight     | Conjuration 5  | E2D1        | 3 Earth gems   | 1 Hound of Twilight            | No native Death             |
| Craft Keledone               | Construction 6 | E2S2        | 5 Earth gems   | 1 Keledone                     | No natural E2S2 Mystic      |
| Bind Keres                   | Conjuration 6  | D2          | 12 Death gems  | 3 Keres                        | No native Death             |
| Procession of the Underworld | Conjuration 5  | D3          | 13 Death gems  | 15 Lampads                     | No native Death             |
| Awaken Hamadryad             | Enchantment 5  | N4          | 25 Nature gems | 1 N3 Hamadryad                 | Hero or imported path route |
| Monster Boar                 | Conjuration 5  | N3          | 10 Nature gems | Remote unrest monster, range 5 | Hero or imported path route |

## National access is not castability

Five of the eight entries are not immediately castable by the normal recruitable roster. This is deliberate strategic terrain.

- Sow Dragon Teeth is the clean native national tool.
- Craft Keledone requires bridging the missing point on an E2S1 or another caster.
- Forge Brass Bull requires substantial dual-path elevation.
- the Death rituals require imported or bootstrapped Death;
- high Nature depends on a hero, Pretender, independent, empowerment, or another chain.

The dossier separates "the nation owns this ritual" from "the present game can cast it."

## Path-access ladder

### Fire

- 1 Recruit Mystics until F1 and F2 roles are available.
- 2 Use communion bonuses or a Fire self-buff to reach battlefield thresholds.
- 3 Forge only after confirming the current item path and Construction level.
- 4 Use Pretender Fire when a ritual requires a dual path the Mystic distribution cannot produce.

### Water

- 1 Recruit W1 and W2 Mystics.
- 2 Use Water self-buffs and communions for battlefield scaling.
- 3 Use booster chains when ritual thresholds require them.
- 4 Treat very high Water as a deliberate project rather than normal roster access.

### Earth

- 1 Preserve E2 Mystics.
- 2 Use Earth self-buffs in battle.
- 3 Forge Earth boosters when current research and item paths allow.
- 4 Use E2 to cast Sow Dragon Teeth.
- 5 Bridge E2S1 to E2S2 for Craft Keledone through a named Astral booster or another caster.

### Astral

- 1 Every Mystic provides S1.
- 2 S2 Mystics become stronger masters and forgers.
- 3 Astrologers provide S3, commonly S4, and rarely S5.
- 4 Astral boosters extend high rituals and penetration.
- 5 Communions reach extreme battlefield levels but do not cast ordinary rituals.

### Nature

- 1 Hieresai and Archousai provide N1.
- 2 The national hero Axieros provides N3 if he appears.
- 3 A single Nature booster can bring N3 to N4 for Awaken Hamadryad, subject to current item legality.
- 4 Pretender or independent access can make the route reliable.

### Death

- 1 There is no recruitable national Death.
- 2 A Pretender is the reliable pregame bridge.
- 3 Suitable independent mages, sites, heroes, empowerment, or summons can create a later bridge.



- 4 Once D2 or D3 exists, the national Keres and Lampad rituals can produce units with further magic potential if made commanders by an appropriate current spell.

### Air, Glamour, and Blood

These are absent from the ordinary national roster.

- Air appears on Orokestes at A1, if the hero arrives.
- Glamour and Blood require imported or summon-chain access.
- A Pretender taking one of these paths should have a clear job beyond merely making the national summary look broad.

## Part V: Expansion and the First Year

### Expansion objectives

Arcoscephalian expansion is successful when it produces:

- enough provinces to finance multiple forts and laboratories;
- resource provinces that let those forts recruit the intended line;
- surviving elephants, infantry, and commanders;
- a border that automatic scrying can help cover;
- an early fort schedule that begins multiplying Mystics;
- a credible force against opportunistic neighbours.

Province count alone is insufficient. Eight disconnected or exposed provinces with no second fort can be weaker than six provinces with a defensible boundary and a fort already building.

### Starting force

Unmodded Arcoscephale begins with:

- a Hypaspist Commander;
- a Scout;
- twenty Peltasts;
- twenty Hoplites.

The starting army already contains a screen and an armoured line. It can take suitable human infantry provinces, but the correct first target depends on the actual report. Heavy cavalry, barbarians, crossbows, large numbers, and other high-damage independents can convert the expensive Hoplite line into an early setback.

### Starting formation hypothesis

Strategic doctrine, test pending:

- Hoplites form the central or forward anvil.
- Peltasts begin slightly behind or on a flank so javelins do not disrupt the first contact.
- The commander remains protected and away from the most likely projectile path.
- Orders and distance are adjusted to make the two lines contact in a useful sequence.

This is a starting point for testing, not a universal script. Battlefield terrain, enemy placement, and projectile range alter the timing.

## Expansion engines

### Heavy-infantry expansion

Core: Hoplites or Hypaspists with a proper commander and a cheaper supporting line.

Strengths:

- little dependence on Pretender awakening;
- good against ordinary low-damage infantry;
- survivors retain value in the first war;
- predictable morale and formation.

Weaknesses:

- high resource demand;
- slow map movement for Hoplites;
- attrition from high-damage attacks;
- limited killing speed against dense or armoured enemies;
- replacement can delay infrastructure.

### Elephant expansion

Core: a small number of elephants behind or beside an infantry screen.

Strengths:

- high shock and trample output against smaller human troops;
- fast strategic movement from the mount;
- low resource cost on the rider listing;
- strong deterrent against opponents without prepared counters.

Weaknesses:

- 100 gold per recruit;
- low mount MR and ordinary morale;
- catastrophic losses against control, fear, giants, and anti-large force;
- routs can trample friendly troops;
- a single bad expansion can delay a fort.

The correct number is empirical. It varies with independent strength, screen size, bless, leadership, target composition, and map. The library will not print a "safe" elephant count until repeated tests establish a range under the frozen settings.

### Chariot expansion

Core: chariots on a flank with a centre that holds the enemy.

Strengths:

- cheaper than elephants;
- multiple package elements through rider, corider, and mount;
- mobile ranged and trample pressure;
- useful against light troops.

Weaknesses:

- smaller and easier to stop than elephants;

- less decisive against dense or large targets;
- vulnerable if pinned.

## Awake-expander expansion

An awake combat Pretender can:

- take difficult provinces;
- establish a second route;
- reduce mundane losses;
- deter a first-year attack;
- bring missing magic.

The cost is paid in:

- scales;
- dominion or bless;
- design paths;
- risk to the Pretender;
- healing and support turns;
- the possibility that the chosen chassis cannot safely fight the actual independent.

Arcoscephalian healing makes a recoverable combat Pretender more attractive, but does not make it immortal or immune to lethal counters.

## Target classification

Before each neutral attack, classify the province.

| Independent feature                 | Arcoscephalian concern                                                  |
|-------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Large low-damage infantry           | Heavy line usually favourable; check total numbers and fatigue          |
| Barbarians or high-strength weapons | Protection can be penetrated; use margin and missiles                   |
| Heavy cavalry                       | Lance impact can kill expensive infantry or riders                      |
| Crossbows                           | Heavy armour helps, but concentrated armour-piercing fire still matters |
| Archers and slingers                | Shields and armour help; exposed Peltasts and Slingers suffer           |
| Elephants or other tramlers         | Body size, morale, and formation require a specific plan                |
| Heavy infantry                      | Killing speed may be too low without elephants or magic                 |
| Sacred or unusual independents      | Inspect weapons, paths, morale, and special abilities                   |
| Many commanders or mages            | Assassination, morale, or magic can change the expected fight           |

## Expansion losses and stop rules

An expansion party should stop when:

- its next target is outside the package's favourable class;
- losses would delay a fort or second party;
- the retreat province is unsafe;
- enemy borders make the party easy to trap;
- an elephant or commander has accumulated a material affliction;
- consolidation produces more value than one more exposed province.

The real cost of a dead Hoplite is not thirteen gold. It includes thirty-one resources, recruitment capacity, transport, and the effect of a thinner line on the next battle.

## First-year infrastructure

A robust first year normally needs:

- continued expansion;
- a second expansion party or awake Pretender route;
- a second fort site chosen for population, resources, geometry, and safety;
- a laboratory where the first new Mystic production matters;
- temples where dominion, priest recruitment, or sacred production justify them;
- enough scouts to find neighbours before armies do;
- a treasury reserve against bad events, defence, and fort completion.

The 300-gold laboratory surcharge changes timing. A fort that cannot receive a laboratory on schedule is not yet a Mystic factory.

## Turn-12 test record

Every serious design should be tested through turn 12 with:

- exact scales and awakening;
- exact independent strength;
- map type or seed;
- active mod list and order;
- recruitment by turn;
- Province Defence purchases;
- fort, lab, and temple starts;
- site searching;
- expansion route;
- every battle and loss;
- treasury and gem stock;
- surviving army;
- research level;
- contact and border geometry.

## Minimum comparison metrics

| Metric                     | Why it matters                                  |
|----------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| Provinces owned            | Gross territorial result                        |
| Income                     | Ability to sustain Mystics and infrastructure   |
| Forts completed / building | Future mage throughput                          |
| Labs completed / planned   | Actual conversion of forts into magic           |
| Mage count and randoms     | Research and access                             |
| Expansion-party survivors  | Deterrence and replacement burden               |
| Pretender state            | Wounds, afflictions, location, fatigue and risk |
| Border length              | Defence demand                                  |
| Neighbour contact          | First-war pressure                              |

| Metric           | Why it matters                      |
|------------------|-------------------------------------|
| Research reached | Whether the proposed timing is real |

## Expansion test hypotheses

The first Arcoscephale test suite should compare:

- 1 scales plus starting heavy infantry;
- 2 scales plus early elephants;
- 3 mixed infantry, chariots, and elephants;
- 4 awake combat Pretender;
- 5 dormant intervention Pretender with stronger scales.

For each, test at least:

- ordinary infantry;
- barbarians;
- heavy cavalry;
- crossbows;
- heavy infantry;
- enemy tramlers.

Precise party sizes remain test pending until those runs are saved.

# Part VI: Research Response Trees

## The research trunk

Arcoscephale wants many schools. The solution is not to research every school evenly. It is to reach small conversion nodes that make the present army better, then branch.

A broadly useful trunk is:

- 1 Thaumaturgy 1 for Communion Master and Communion Slave.
- 2 Alteration 3 for Earth Meld, Body Ethereal, Mossbody where the cross-path exists, and a cluster of defensive or control tools.
- 3 Conjunction 3 for Phoenix Power, Summon Earthpower, Power of the Spheres, and early elemental options.
- 4 A branch chosen from the observed enemy.

This is doctrine, not a mandatory order. An immediate rush can require Evocation, Thaumaturgy 2, Construction, or another emergency branch first.

## Exact early and middle conversion nodes

The manual confirms the following relevant spells:

| Node                                    | Requirement | Effect and Arcoscephalian use              |
|-----------------------------------------|-------------|--------------------------------------------|
| Communion Master / Slave, Thaumaturgy 1 | S1          | Creates the national path-elevation system |

| Node                                      | Requirement | Effect and Arcoscephalian use                                             |
|-------------------------------------------|-------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Mind Burn, Thaumaturgy 2                  | S2          | 12+ armour-negating damage, MR negates; early single-target Astral threat |
| Body Ethereal, Alteration 3               | S1          | Point protection against nonmagical attacks                               |
| Earth Meld, Alteration 3                  | E2          | Area movement control                                                     |
| Phoenix Power, Conjunction 3              | F2          | Raises Fire on the caster                                                 |
| Summon Earthpower, Conjunction 3          | E2          | Raises Earth and supplies reinvigoration                                  |
| Power of the Spheres, Conjunction 3       | S1          | Raises the caster's known magic paths                                     |
| Strength of Giants, Enchantment 1         | E2          | Point Strength support                                                    |
| Destruction, Alteration 4                 | E3          | Armour-negating armour damage over area                                   |
| Paralyze, Thaumaturgy 4                   | S2          | MR-negates control against non-mindless targets                           |
| Light of the Northern Star, Conjunction 4 | S3          | Battlefield enchantment raising Astral                                    |
| Falling Fires, Evocation 5                | F3          | Area armour-piercing Fire damage                                          |
| Falling Frost, Evocation 5                | W3          | Area armour-piercing Cold damage                                          |
| Gifts from Heaven, Evocation 5            | E3S1        | Very high damage with low precision; dangerous near friendly troops       |
| Stellar Cascades, Evocation 5             | S2          | Area armour-piercing fatigue damage                                       |
| Soul Slay, Thaumaturgy 5                  | S3          | MR-negates death against a single non-mindless target                     |
| Mind Hunt, Evocation 6                    | S4          | Remote commander attack; detection and feeblemind risk matter             |
| Sow Dragon Teeth, Enchantment 6           | E2 + 1 gem  | Ten national Spartae in battle                                            |
| Marble Warriors, Alteration 7             | E3          | Large-area protection for non-spirit targets                              |
| Will of the Fates, Alteration 7           | S5          | Battlefield-wide Luck                                                     |
| Legions of Steel, Construction 6          | E4          | Battlefield-wide armour improvement                                       |
| Army of Lead, Alteration 9                | E5S1        | Battlefield-wide major protection                                         |
| Army of Gold, Alteration 9                | E5F1        | Battlefield-wide major protection                                         |
| Master Enslave, Thaumaturgy 9             | S8          | Battlefield-wide MR-negates enslavement against eligible minds            |

The table gives capabilities, not recommended scripts. Friendly-fire risk, magic resistance, fatigue, gem cost, battlefield range, and enemy resistance still determine value.

## Branch A: anti-armour

### Problem

Enemy protection makes mundane spears and tramlers trade poorly.

### Early answer

- Destruction at Alteration 4 from an E3 caster.
- An E2 Mystic reaches E3 through Summon Earthpower or a two-slave communion.
- Ordinary infantry and tramlers exploit the reduced armour.

## Middle answer

- combine armour destruction with Falling Fires, Gifts from Heaven, elementals, or strengthened troops;
- use Stellar Cascades if fatigue rather than immediate kills is the better axis;
- avoid concentrating expensive magic into a battle the enemy can decline.

## Failure branch

If Destruction misses the relevant squares, or if raw HP and size matter more than Magic Resistance, add control, high damage, or more attacks. Repeating armour reduction will not solve that problem.

## Branch B: anti-elite and anti-giant

### Problem

Few high-stat or giant troops defeat ordinary lines and cannot be trampled efficiently.

### Tools

- Earth Meld to hold targets;
- Body Ethereal on critical blockers;
- Mind Burn, Paralyze, and Soul Slay where MR permits;
- Gifts from Heaven for extreme physical damage at accepted accuracy risk;
- elementals to create size and disruption;
- Destruction if armour is the main defence;
- fatigue through Stellar Cascades or prolonged combat;
- a properly chosen Pretender or thug.

### Doctrine

Do not ask one spell to do every job. A complete anti-elite package needs:

- 1 a line that survives initial contact;
- 2 control or distraction;
- 3 damage that attacks the correct defence;
- 4 mage protection;
- 5 a plan if the elite force attacks the rear or refuses the centre.

## Branch C: anti-mass

### Problem

Large numbers surround the line and exhaust killing capacity.

### Tools

- elephants and chariots against eligible sizes;
- Falling Fires or Falling Frost against low resistance;
- area control;
- summoned elementals;
- dense formation infantry to hold frontage;
- Fire or Cold resistance on friendly forces when using hazardous battlefield conditions.

## Failure branch

If the enemy mass is mindless, do not rely on mind effects. If it is undead, add priests and check the exact banishment environment. If it contains sacrificial chaff protecting dangerous mages, rear pressure or remote commander attacks may matter more than killing every body.

## Branch D: anti-undead and anti-demon

### Assets

- H1 and H2 priestesses;
- a prophet or Pretender;
- Astral, Fire, and national summoned options;
- morale support;
- precise information from dominion scrying.

### Requirements

- enough priests to matter at battlefield scale;
- bodyguards against undead flyers or assassins;
- protection against fear and fatigue;
- Spirit Sight or another answer when darkness, invisibility, or special sight is relevant;
- an answer to the enemy mages rather than only the undead screen.

The ordinary infantry may hold skeletons but can be exhausted by endless replacement. The strategic target is often the summoning engine.

## Branch E: anti-rush

The emergency branch is selected after reading the neighbour.

| Rush feature             | Candidate response                                              |
|--------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| High protection          | Alteration 4 for Destruction                                    |
| Few elite sacreds        | Thaumaturgy 2/4, control, elementals, body-blocking             |
| Giants                   | Control, high damage, fatigue, avoid elephant dependence        |
| Flyers                   | Rear guards, dispersed mages, bodyguards, wider deployment      |
| Fire or Cold aura        | Resistance, spacing, ranged damage, suitable element            |
| Glamour and high defence | Spirit Sight where available, area effects, attack improvement  |
| Regeneration             | Concentrated damage, decay or disease where accessible, control |
| Undead mass              | Priests, morale, engine-killing                                 |

Construction can be an anti-rush branch if a combat Pretender or thug is the fastest viable answer. It is not automatically useful merely because items are permanent.

## Branch F: remote Astral control



## Mind Hunt

Mind Hunt is Evocation 6, S4, two Astral pearls, range six.

Arcoscephale can obtain S4 on capital Astrologers without boosters, though not every Astrologer is S4. Healing reduces the long-term cost of some recoverable afflictions, but does not remove detection risk or make indiscriminate hunting sound.

Targets should be chosen from:

- commanders outside Astral protection;
- siege leaders;
- critical priests;
- isolated thugs;
- laboratory mages exposed by scrying and scouts.

The package includes:

- target intelligence;
- several S4 casters if the objective justifies them;
- a safe laboratory;
- pearls;
- healing capacity;
- a plan for enemy Astral detection or domes.

## Soul Slay and Master Enslave

Soul Slay is a battlefield precision tool against eligible high-value units. Master Enslave is an endgame operation, not a research aspiration in isolation.

A Master Enslave operation needs:

- S8 effective skill;
- a robust communion;
- penetration;
- protection from interruption;
- enough fatigue support;
- a plan for mindless and high-MR enemies;
- commanders able to control any captured units;
- an exploitation plan if the enemy army is stolen.

## Branch G: battlefield renewal

Arcoscephale's mundane army scales when research makes old soldiers survive modern magic.

Key transformations include:

- point ethereal and protection effects on the contact line;
- Destruction making ordinary spears relevant against armour;
- Marble Warriors improving a broad formation;
- Will of the Fates reducing casualties across the army;
- Legions of Steel improving worn armour;
- Army of Lead or Gold creating a late-game protected mass.

The more expensive the buff package, the more important it is to ask whether the troops are the right recipients. A battlefield-wide spell does not make a routed, immobile, poisoned, or bypassed army successful by itself.

## Research rejoin points

Emergency branches should rejoin a larger plan.

Examples:

- Thaumaturgy 2 anti-elite -> Thaumaturgy 5 for Soul Slay -> Evocation 6 for Mind Hunt;
- Alteration 4 anti-armour -> Alteration 7 for Marble Warriors and Will of the Fates -> Alteration 9;
- Evocation 5 damage -> Evocation 6 remote Astral -> later battlefield offence;
- Conjunction 3 self-buffs -> Conjunction 4 Northern Star -> national and elemental summons;
- Construction branch for a Pretender -> boosters -> ritual access.

The rejoin point should be recorded before emergency research begins, preventing a permanent drift across half-finished schools.

## Part VII: Army Packages

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### Package 1: The old line

Purpose: defeat ordinary human troops and hold ground cheaply.

Core:

- Hoplite or Hypaspist centre;
- Cardaces or Peltasts as screen or flank;
- one reliable commander;
- optional Hiereia;
- scouts on the operational route.

Scaling:

- add a Strategos for a larger army;
- add elephants or chariots for killing power;
- add a small Mystic cell once research provides a specific effect.

Failure modes:

- high-damage weapons penetrate the line;
- fatigue breaks Hoplites;
- flyers reach the rear;
- the army cannot kill high protection;
- slow movement cedes operational initiative.

### Package 2: The elephant hammer

Purpose: break large formations of smaller ordinary troops.

Core:

- infantry screen;
- elephant group on a flank or behind the line;
- commander with adequate leadership and morale support;
- rear guard;
- scouting of size, morale attacks, and MR-negates magic.

Scaling:

- add enough elephants to create simultaneous contact;
- add point buffs to the screen;
- add area damage or control so elephants are not stopped by elites;
- add Hiereia/Archousa support and a post-battle healing route.

Failure modes:

- panic or control;
- giants;
- rear attack on commanders;
- a narrow battlefield;
- friendly trampling during rout;
- overinvestment in a countered chassis.

## Package 3: Independent Mystic battery

Purpose: obtain many useful casts without communion concentration.

Core:

- several Mystics selected for the same low-level effect;
- one pearl or relevant elemental gems where needed;
- heavy infantry screen;
- separation and bodyguards;
- strict scripts whose unscripted continuation is acceptable.

Examples:

- repeated Body Ethereal;
- Mind Burn from S2 casters;
- Power of the Spheres followed by elemental effects;
- small elemental summons;
- repeated point buffs.

Strength: every mage acts.

Failure: individual path and gem use may be less powerful than a communion; spell-selection variance can scatter effects.

## Package 4: Four-slave elemental communion

Purpose: turn common elemental randoms into level-three battlefield casters.

Core:

- four Communion Slaves;
- one or two chosen masters;
- screen and rear guard;
- gem load calculated from the exact script;
- no unnecessary masters.

Candidate master outcomes:

- F1 -> F3;
- W1 -> W3;

- E1 -> E3;
- S1 -> S3.

Self-buffs can raise paths further, but also change fatigue relationships and must be tested.

Failure: slave fatigue, lost threshold, massed mage casualties, or masters improvising expensive spells.

## Package 5: Astral elimination cell

Purpose: remove a few high-value eligible targets.

Core:

- Astrologers or appropriate masters;
- Soul Slay or another current Astral killing spell;
- penetration where available;
- a line long enough to permit repeated casts;
- target selection based on MR and mind status.

Failure: high MR, mindlessness, enemy Magic Duel threat, insufficient range, or line collapse.

## Package 6: Armour-break combined arms

Purpose: let ordinary troops and tramlers defeat armour.

Core:

- E3 effective caster for Destruction;
- resilient screen;
- Hypaspists, elephants, chariots, or summoned bodies ready to exploit;
- secondary magic if armour destruction lands unevenly.

Failure: the enemy disperses, kills the Earth caster, relies on innate protection, or counters the exploitation force.

## Package 7: Fort storm and Throne claim

Purpose: convert field advantage into victory position.

Core:

- sufficient siege bodies;
- a storming line;
- an anti-commander or anti-mage plan;
- H2 or H3 claim capacity as required by the Throne;
- supply and laboratory support;
- a relief interception force;
- replacement commanders.

Arcoscephale's strength in field magic does not automatically crack walls or claim Thrones. The claim-capable priest and army must arrive together after the fort falls.

## Package 8: Distributed counter-raiding

Purpose: prevent fast or stealth forces from turning a slow main army into territorial collapse.

Core:

- dominion scrying on approaches;
- scouts outside dominion;
- small Mystic cells in protected labs;
- cheap commanders and local troops;
- mobile elephants, chariots, or a Pretender where suitable;
- fort and laboratory redundancy.

Failure: every cell is too weak, pearls are absent, or the main army cannot exploit the enemy's dispersion.

## Part VIII: Pretender Families

---

### Family A: Awake expansion and missing path

#### Job

- take difficult neutral provinces;
- preserve national troops;
- deter an early rush;
- bring one or two missing paths, commonly Death, Air, Glamour, or another ritual bridge.

#### Good fit

- crowded maps;
- dangerous neighbours;
- weak starting terrain;
- a design whose chassis can reliably expand under the actual settings.

#### Costs

- weaker scales;
- Pretender risk;
- fewer design points for broad ritual access;
- possible overlap with elephants.

#### Audit

The chassis must be tested against heavy cavalry, barbarians, poison, magic weapons, and MR attacks. Healing is a recovery advantage, not a licence to attack unknown targets.

### Family B: Dormant intervention platform

### Job

- stronger scales than an awake expander;
- arrive near the first serious war;
- carry missing paths;
- serve as thug, battlefield caster, forger, or ritual bridge.

### Good fit

- national troops can expand;
- the likely danger begins after contact;
- the nation wants a high-impact mid-game path package.

### Costs

- no help during the first expansion turns;
- the planned battlefield role can be invalidated by the actual neighbour;
- a dormant chassis that cannot move or fight as expected may become an expensive researcher.

## Family C: Imprisoned scales and research

### Job

- maximise gold, resources, growth, and research scales;
- multiply forts and Mystics;
- emerge as a late ritual platform.

### Good fit

- spacious map;
- reliable troop expansion;
- diplomatic room;
- a plan that uses the additional economic throughput before awakening.

### Costs

- no Pretender during expansion or first war;
- greater vulnerability to rush;
- high-path ritual promises may arrive after the decisive period.

The design succeeds only if the recruitable state survives long enough to compound.

## Family D: Sacred-support hybrid

### Job

- provide an incidental or moderate bless to Heart Companions;
- remain useful as an expander, battlefield caster, or ritual bridge.

### Good fit

- the capital can recruit Companions without sacrificing the rest of the plan;
- the bless also improves sacred commanders, summons, or the Pretender;

- the sacred unit fills a clear tactical role.

## Costs

- capital-only recruitment;
- heavy resources;
- slow map movement;
- bless points that could solve wider national constraints.

## Family E: Ritual bridge

### Job

Provide paths missing from the national roster.

Priority candidates:

- Death for the national Underworld summons and wider Death economy;
- Air for mobility, lightning, forging, and storm tools;
- Glamour for sight, illusion, and control options;
- Blood only if the design includes a credible way to create and sustain a Blood economy;
- high Nature for national N3/N4 rituals and global access.

### Audit

For every promised ritual, write the complete route:

```
Pretender base path
+ named booster
+ empowerment if any
+ research level
+ gem cost
+ laboratory and province requirement
= legal caster
```

If one step is missing, the ritual is not part of the build.

## Historical builds and current legality

Earlier project discussions proposed:

- an imprisoned Astral-Earth Titan;
- a dormant Great Enchantress with Astral, Earth, Nature, and Death;
- a later Grand Hierophant with Fire, Air, Astral, and Blood under the combined mod set.

These are retained as historical design families, not copied as current legal builds. Chassis paths, design costs, scale limits, blesses, and mod abilities must be rebuilt in the current Pretender screen before publication as finished designs.

## Scale priorities

### Order

Supports:

- expensive mage recruitment;
- fort and laboratory construction;
- elephants and ordinary armies.

The national +1 limit makes high Order available, but the final value depends on the design-point curve and map economy.

## Production

Supports:

- Hoplites;
- Hypaspists;
- Heart Companions;
- fort provinces with strong local resources.

Elephants themselves are not resource-intensive on the rider listing, so an elephant-heavy opening can use gold faster than resources.

## Growth

Supports:

- long-run income;
- population resilience;
- supplies;
- Blood resistance if Blood Hunting occurs nearby;
- campaigns expected to last.

## Magic

Supports:

- Research Points;
- spell performance through the scale's ordinary effects;
- the national plan of reaching several response nodes.

It also affects enemy magic in the same province and may interact with events. It is not an uncontested bonus.

## Luck

Interacts with events and the concentration of Astrologer Fortune Tellers. It should be evaluated as part of the whole event policy, not only because the nation uses Astrologers.

## Temperature

Choose after checking:

- national preference;
- design points;
- income and supplies;
- expected battlefield effects;
- mod changes.



## Sloth

Sloth purchases design points by taxing a roster that contains resource-heavy infantry and sacreds. It is more plausible in an elephant- or magic-heavy design than in one promising massed Hoplites and Heart Companions.

# Part IX: Campaign Doctrine

## Early game

### Objectives

- expand without crippling attrition;
- identify neighbours before contact becomes war;
- begin the second fort and its 300-gold laboratory;
- recruit the first Mystic portfolio;
- retain enough mundane force to deter a rush;
- choose research from observed threats.

### Questions each turn

- Which independent class is the next target?
- Is a valuable elephant or commander entering an uncertain battle?
- Does the treasury still meet the fort and laboratory schedule?
- Which Mystic random appeared, and has it been recorded?
- Which neighbour can reach the capital fastest?
- Does the research branch produce a complete package before that attack?

### Common early failure

Arcoscephale can spend on everything:

- 190-gold Mystics;
- 270-gold Astrologers;
- 100-gold elephants;
- forts;
- 300-gold labs;
- ordinary armies.

The nation risks buying one of each and completing none of its conversions. A plan should state the current priority:

expansion force  
or infrastructure  
or mage throughput  
or emergency defence

The other categories receive maintenance, not equal spending.

## First war

### War aim

The first war should have a positional aim:

- remove a dangerous rush neighbour;
- seize a fort cluster;
- secure a Throne corridor;
- take a high-income or high-gem region;
- shorten the border;
- destroy an exposed mage core.

"Use the research lead" is not a war aim.

### Preparation

Record:

- enemy troop defence classes;
- known magic paths and school evidence;
- likely battlefield enchantments;
- routes and retreat provinces;
- fort wall strength and relief distance;
- required gems by battle;
- replacement Mystic production;
- the branch if the first army is countered.

### First-war strengths

- heavy infantry can anchor;
- elephants punish unprepared human formations;
- Mystics can tailor several low- and middle-level packages;
- automatic scrying improves defence inside dominion;
- healing preserves expensive survivors;
- Astrologers threaten high Astral.

### First-war weaknesses

- most mages are expensive human bodies;
- a large communion risks a national research disaster;
- no normal Death, Air, Glamour, or Blood limits adaptation;
- tramlers have clear morale and MR counters;
- heavy infantry can be bypassed or fatigued;
- the 300-gold lab cost slows replacement infrastructure.

## Middle game

The middle game begins when the nation has several forts, multiple Mystic cohorts, and enough research that the opponent must respect several branches.

## Objectives

- turn random-mage breadth into repeatable packages;
- establish booster and gem logistics;
- create at least one remote or mobile threat;
- defend the capital Astrologer pipeline;
- convert won battles into forts and labs;
- begin a Throne claim plan.

## Portfolio doctrine

Do not send the entire mage corps with one army. Divide it into:

- research reserve;
- main field package;
- counter-raiding cells;
- ritual and forging specialists;
- capital Astral core;
- healing and recovery hubs.

The exact proportions change during war. The distinction prevents the same mage from being promised simultaneously to research, forge, cast a ritual, and fight.

## Late game

### National late-game strengths

- accumulated Astral;
- communions capable of high battlefield paths;
- broad elemental response;
- strong research if the fort network survived;
- information across friendly dominion;
- healing of valuable commanders;
- access to high-end Astral rituals and battlefield magic.

### National late-game limits

- low innate non-Astral path ceilings;
- absent Death, Air, Glamour, and Blood unless bridged;
- mortal human mage core;
- expensive fort and lab replacement;
- capital dependence for Astrologers;
- greater enemy ability to clear dense armies and communions.

### Late-game transition

The old army should become one of several shells around the magic:

- protected mass;
- siege and Throne body;
- screen for remote or high-Astral operations;
- distributed defence;
- disposable frontage for summons.

If every late-game battle still depends on unmodified Hoplites and elephants reaching melee, research has not been converted.

## Endgame and Thrones

An endgame plan states:

- current Ascension Points;
- claimable Thrones and required priest levels;
- forts and walls on each target;
- enemy relief routes;
- magic-phase threats;
- claim timing;
- the army that survives after the storm;
- the diplomatic response to visible victory progress.

Arcoscephale's H2 Archousa can claim Thrones that require H2. Higher requirements need a prophet, Pretender, hero, or imported priest.

Automatic scrying helps defend claimed territory inside dominion, but the victory turn may depend on simultaneous attacks beyond that information umbrella.

## Raiding

### Native raiders

Unmodded Arcoscephale is not defined by stealth thugs or flying sacreds. Native options are modest:

- small conventional troop groups;
- chariot or elephant detachments against known weak defence;
- a combat Pretender;
- a geared commander when Construction and target class justify it;
- remote Astral attacks against commanders rather than province capture.

### Raiding doctrine

The nation should raid to:

- cut reinforcement routes;
- take laboratories;
- force counters away from the decisive siege;
- break a dominion or temple corridor;
- isolate a fort;
- punish an enemy who concentrated against the main line.

Slow heavy infantry should not chase fast raiders province by province. Scrying, forts, Mystic cells, mobile tramlers, and prediction form the counter-raiding system.

## Sieges

The roster supplies many human siege bodies but no automatic siege miracle.

Before besieging:

- calculate whether the army can breach on the required deadline;
- protect the lab and gem route;
- keep enough field power to defeat relief;
- preserve a storming package distinct from wall damage;
- move a claim-capable priest toward any Throne;
- scout every adjacent retreat.

Mystics researching inside a siege army are not free value if a relief battle destroys them.

## Diplomacy

Arcoscephale presents two political images.

The visible image is a conventional human kingdom with slow infantry and elephants. The hidden image is a rapidly compounding Astral state capable of communions, remote attacks, and high research.

This creates predictable diplomacy:

- neighbours may seek an early war before the mage network matures;
- others may value Arcoscephale as a stable border or anti-elite partner;
- Mind Hunt and Master Enslave potential can make later coalitions wary;
- scrying makes covert movement inside dominion less reliable;
- broad but shallow paths create useful gem and item trades.

Good diplomacy communicates enough strength to deter without advertising every random and research branch.

## Matchup framework

### Against heavy armour

Prefer:

- Destruction;
- high-damage or armour-negating magic;
- fatigue;
- elementals;
- a protected line that buys casting time.

Avoid:

- relying on ordinary spear damage alone;
- sending elephants into elite armour without disruption.

### Against giants

Prefer:

- Earth Meld and other control;
- Gifts from Heaven or other high-damage effects;
- fatigue and MR pressure;
- enough line depth to prevent immediate mage contact.

Avoid:

- treating trample as the primary answer;
- spending heavily on protection that giant damage easily penetrates without another plan.

### **Against high-MR elites**

Prefer:

- physical control and damage;
- armour destruction;
- fatigue that does not depend on one MR check;
- penetration only when the arithmetic is credible.

Avoid:

- a pure Soul Slay plan without enough attempts and penetration.

### **Against undead mass**

Prefer:

- priest support;
- engine killing;
- morale protection;
- fire, area damage, and fatigue tools appropriate to the exact undead;
- sustained lines that do not exhaust before the summoners.

Avoid:

- counting skeleton kills without measuring mage fatigue and replacement.

### **Against flyers and attack-rear forces**

Prefer:

- rear guards;
- mage bodyguards;
- wider or staggered deployment;
- separated mage cells;
- predictive interception through scrying.

Avoid:

- a single unguarded communion block.

### **Against glamour and stealth**

Prefer:

- dominion scrying;
- Spirit Sight or other current sight tools;
- area effects;
- patrol networks;
- redundant defence.

Avoid:

- assuming a missing army is absent.

## Against enemy Astral

Prefer:

- explicit Magic Duel policy;
- non-Astral damage where possible;
- protecting high-S Astrologers;
- decoy and target-priority planning;
- assessing enemy penetration and remote threat.

Avoid:

- exposing irreplaceable high-S casters to cheap duellists without need.

## Heroes

The unmodded national hero pool includes:

| Hero                  | Strategic contribution                                         |
|-----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|
| Anthromachus          | Inspirational military leadership                              |
| Orokestes, Hierophant | F1A1W1E1S2H2; unique Air and broad cross-path access           |
| Pathos, Son of Titans | Durable inspirational hero with Awe and Invulnerability        |
| Axieros, Kabeiride    | W1N3H2, Healing 3, Sailing, recuperation and support abilities |

Heroes are opportunities, not foundations. A plan that requires Axieros for N3 or Orokestes for Air has no deadline guarantee unless the hero is already present.

When a hero appears:

- 1 record the exact paths and abilities in the current version;
- 2 identify unique items, rituals, or movement unlocked;
- 3 protect the hero according to replacement impossibility;
- 4 avoid forcing the hero into a role a repeatable recruit can perform.

## Gem economy

The capital produces four Astral pearls and one Nature gem per month.

Astral pearls compete among:

- communions and Power of the Spheres;
- battlefield Astral;
- forging;
- remote magic;
- boosters;
- globals;
- high-end rituals;
- reserve against an unexpected war.

Nature gems compete among:

- support summons;
- boosters;
- national Monster Boar or Hamadryad routes after access exists;

- later globals;
- trades that buy missing Death, Air, or other resources.

An Astral-rich nation can still run out of pearls if every Mystic receives one for every battle. Gem budgets should be assigned by operation, not distributed by habit.

## Laboratory and item security

Because labs cost 300 gold and pool gems:

- do not leave the only forward laboratory exposed;
- keep irreplaceable boosters off commanders taking uncertain routes;
- maintain a rear laboratory for recovery;
- transfer operation gems shortly before commitment;
- record item ownership;
- include retreats and laboratory capture in the invasion ledger.

## New-player turn checklist

### Recruitment

- Is every fort recruiting the commander it needs?
- Was a rare Mystic random identified?
- Is the capital buying an Astrologer for a defined job?
- Can a Hiereia be recruited outside a fort instead?
- Does troop recruitment match local gold and resources?

### Research

- What enemy problem does the current school solve?
- Which mage can cast the spell?
- Does the caster need a communion, self-buff, gem, or item?
- Will the army and caster reach the same battle?

### Armies

- Are elephants screened?
- Is the rear protected?
- Is the commander safe?
- Are retreat provinces friendly?
- Are slow Hoplitcs delaying an urgent operation?

### Economy

- Is the next fort still affordable?
- Has the 300-gold lab been budgeted?
- Are pearls reserved for the next operation?
- Is a mage promised to both research and fight?

### Information

- What is seen by scouts?
- What is seen only by dominion scrying?



- Which report is stale?
- Could the missing force use stealth or magic movement?

## Expert turn audit

- Recalculate specialist probabilities against current recruitment.
- Separate native, boosted, bootstrapped, and imported path claims.
- Compare independent casting with communion opportunity cost.
- Check every master/slave path and fatigue relationship.
- Audit post-script spell-selection risk.
- Check Magic Duel exposure.
- Recalculate siege and relief clocks.
- Mark every S4+ Astrologer and rare dual-path asset.
- Protect capital recruitment and laboratory continuity.
- Update Throne claim capacity and simultaneous victory threats.

# Part X: Dominions Enhanced 2.16

## Scope of the overhaul

Dominions Enhanced 2.16 genuinely overhauls MA Arcoscephale. The changes go well beyond one adjusted cost.

Source-confirmed changes include:

- a rebuilt ordinary troop roster;
- new phalangite and cavalry units;
- a new mounted commander;
- revised Hoplites, Hypaspists, Heart Companions, Archousai, Mystics, and Astrologers;
- paired Heart Companion recruitment at national sites;
- capital Hetairoi;
- a different hero pool and multihero;
- a large national spell and summon suite;
- national items;
- new late-game Titans, nymphs, heroes, and constellation magic.

The strategic identity changes from "broad low-elemental Astral nation with several inaccessible nationals" to "Astral combined arms with a geography-dependent summon ladder capable of opening most missing paths."

## Recruitment rewrite

The nation block clears ordinary recruitment and then rebuilds access.

### Fort commanders

All listed terrain forts receive:

- Scout;
- Lokhagos;
- Hipparchus;

- Strategos;
- Mystic;
- Archousa;
- Hiereia.

The Hiereia is also added outside forts in plains, forests, mountains, swamps, wastes, farms, and caves.

Capital Astrologer access remains tied to the Tower of a Thousand Stars rather than the rebuilt ordinary fort list.

## Ordinary troops

The rebuilt list contains:

- Slinger;
- Peltast;
- Cardaces;
- Hoplite;
- Phalangite;
- Hypaspist;
- Prodromoi;
- Chariot;
- Elephant.

Hetairoi are defined but commented out of the ordinary list. They are instead placed at the Tower of a Thousand Stars. Paired Heart Companions are placed at that site and at the Gymnasium.

## Starting army

The mod sets:

- Lokhagos as starting commander;
- Scout as starting scout;
- twenty Peltasts;
- twenty Hoplites.

## Revised and new units

### Hoplite

Source-confirmed delta:

- Defence 11;
- effective gold setting 11 in the mod source;
- new sprites.

Compared with the unmodded 13-gold Defence-9 Hoplite, this is a substantial efficiency and survival improvement.

### Hypaspist

Source-confirmed delta:

- Attack 12;

- Defence 13;
- Combat Speed 14;
- effective gold setting 12.

The source contains two consecutive Defence assignments, 11 then 13; the later value controls. The unit becomes a faster and cheaper elite line rather than merely the flexible alternative to a Hoplite.

### **Phalangite, unit 9316**

The new MA Phalangite:

- uses half plate, Hoplite helmet, and buckler;
- wields a Sarissa;
- has HP 11, Strength 11, Attack 12, Defence 12;
- costs 16 recruitment points;
- uses the source's effective 13-gold setting.

The long Sarissa and lighter armour define a more offensive formation unit than the old Hoplite.

### **Prodromoi, unit 9317**

The Prodromoi are light cavalry:

- Xyston, broad sword, and javelin;
- ring-mail hauberk, half helmet, and buckler;
- Skilled Rider 3;
- leather-barding horse;
- HP 11, Attack 11, Defence 11, Morale 12;
- 13 recruitment points;
- effective 10-gold setting.

They add cheap mobile flank and skirmish pressure that vanilla MA Arcoscephale lacks.

### **Hetairoi, unit 9318**

The Hetairoi are capital-site heavy cavalry:

- half plate, half helmet, and buckler;
- Xyston, broad sword, and javelin;
- Skilled Rider 5;
- light scale-barding horse;
- HP 13, Strength 12, Attack 12, Defence 12, Morale 12.

Their cost and recruitment values are inherited from the copied Agema Companion because the proposed explicit overrides are commented out. The exact final in-game card remains a combined-object verification item.

### **Hipparchus, unit 9319**

The Hipparchus is the matching cavalry commander:

- same main equipment family as the Hetairoi;
- Skilled Rider 6;
- light scale-barding horse;
- HP 13, Attack 12, Defence 12, Morale 12;
- inherited leadership and costs from the Agema Commander.

The final inherited values should be captured from the live modded unit card before publication of a numeric quick-reference.

## Heart Companions in pairs

Unit 9322 represents paired recruitment:

- source cost 50 gold;
- recruitment-point cost 46;
- resource cost 28;
- Plate Hauberk, Hoplite Helmet, Buckler, Sarissa;
- Morale 14, Strength 12, Attack 12;
- description explicitly states that two are recruited at once.

Seasonal shapes and nation events convert the paired representation into two ordinary Heart Companions. The ordinary Heart Companion is also rewritten with the same equipment family and improved Morale, Strength, and Attack.

This changes sacred economics:

- the recruitment purchase is indivisible;
- the effective body cost is nominally half the pair cost;
- capital and Gymnasium access matters;
- bless value must be recalculated against two-at-a-time production;
- the transformation/event timing should be reproduced before assuming both bodies are immediately available in every interface.

## Archousa

The Archousa becomes:

- N2 rather than N1;
- 265 gold rather than 235.

This single path increase is strategically central. It turns high Nature from a hero-dependent hope into a booster and summon-ladder project.

## Mystic

The Mystic gains Poor Magic Leadership.

The magic random structure is not cleared or rewritten in the inspected source, so the unmodded path distribution remains unless another loaded layer changes it. Poor Magic Leadership matters when summoned magic beings are moved with Mystic armies.

## Astrologer

The Astrologer gains permission to use restricted-item group 10, enabling the national Zodiac item. The base path structure is not rewritten in the inspected source.

## Site recruitment

## Tower of a Thousand Stars

Dominions Enhanced clears and rewrites the site:

- 4 Astral pearls per month;
- 1 Nature gem per month;
- Astrologer as home commander;
- paired Heart Companions;
- Hetairoi.

## Gymnasium

The Gymnasium is rewritten to provide paired Heart Companions.

This creates two sacred-production cases:

- capital production from the Tower;
- any obtained Gymnasium site.

The frequency and map availability of Gymnasias are not a guaranteed national resource and should not be assumed at Pretender design.

## Hero rewrite

The MA national hero line becomes:

- Aleksandros, the Conqueror;
- Orokestes;
- Pathos;
- Axieros;
- Muse as multihero.

## Aleksandros

Aleksandros replaces Anthromachus in the era's primary hero slot. The source defines:

- mounted movement;
- Awe and Fear;
- Inspirational 2;
- high leadership;
- sacred status;
- enchanted equipment;
- events that rally local population types when he is present.

The rally events can generate troops and commanders from horse tribes, Raptorians, several Amazon types, elephant populations, Atavi, and other local groups. These are opportunity effects dependent on both the hero and province population type.

## Muses

Muses are repeatable multiheroes with:

- Glamour 3;
- two random picks from a Fire/Air/Astral/Nature mask in the source;
- Awe, stealth, seduction, Inspirational 2, and Inspiring Research 1;
- sacred and magic-being status.

They can open valuable paths, but hero arrival remains non-deterministic. A deadline-safe plan cannot require a Muse.

Adventurers and Divine Heroes

The nation receives future-site pools for:

- adventurer heroes;
- Divine Heroes;
- ordinary national heroes;
- a broad summon catalogue.

These pools support national spells. They are not ordinary recruits.

National spell suite

The source-confirmed DE suite is grouped below by strategic function. Fields inherited through #copyspell should be checked on the final in-game spell card; explicit overridden values are reliable source claims.

Immediate and battlefield magic

| Spell                             | Research | Explicit requirement    | Cost                        | Effect                                                                                   |
|-----------------------------------|----------|-------------------------|-----------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Zodiac Cascades                   | 0        | S1                      | 0                           | Modified Stellar Cascades, AoE 3, Precision +5; unavailable in caves                     |
| Light of the Aries Constellation  | 4        | S4F1                    | Inherits Northern Star cost | Fire +1 and Astral +1 to eligible casters; Fire Resistance 5 to battlefield              |
| Light of the Cetus Constellation  | 5        | S4W1                    | Inherits Northern Star cost | Astral +1; battlefield speed -25%, +3 encumbrance, d4 fatigue per square moved           |
| Light of the Taurus Constellation | 6        | S4E1                    | Inherits Northern Star cost | Earth +1, Astral +1, Reinvigoration 4                                                    |
| Dissolve into Atoms               | 7        | Inherits Soul Slay path | 20 fatigue                  | AoE 1, MR negates, soul slay; ethereal targets are harder to affect                      |
| Light of the Libra Constellation  | 7        | S6                      | Inherits Northern Star cost | Spirit Sight to battlefield and Astral +1                                                |
| Summon Daimones                   | 7        | S4                      | 3 pearls                    | Twelve sacred ethereal Daimones; secondary effect gives Luck to 25% of friendly soldiers |

The four constellation lights are mutually incompatible with each other and with an Arcoscephalian Light of the Northern Star. They are a strategic choice, not cumulative path stacking.

Astral economy and events

| Spell               | Research | Requirement                  | Cost      | Effect                                                                                  |
|---------------------|----------|------------------------------|-----------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Power of the Zodiac | 5        | Inherited from Stellar Focus | 25 pearls | Produces five Astral pearls per month; attempts to override Stellar Focus; not in caves |

| Spell                  | Research              | Requirement | Cost      | Effect                                                                      |
|------------------------|-----------------------|-------------|-----------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Call to Adventure      | Thaumaturgy 4         | S4          | 15 pearls | Summons a band drawn from the national adventurer montage                   |
| Baleful Conjunction    | Inherits Baleful Star | Inherited   | 4 pearls  | Mountain cast; +30 unrest, Misfortune +3, 10% of units cursed through event |
| Beneficent Conjunction | Inherits Baleful Star | Inherited   | 4 pearls  | Mountain cast; -30 unrest, Luck +3, 10% tax boost through event             |
| Cursed Omen            | 6                     | Inherited   | 5 pearls  | Mountain cast; event intended to curse half the target army                 |

Event-based ritual outcomes and temporary scale duration should be reproduced under the combined mods.

## Nature and elemental summon ladder

| Summon                  | Research | Requirement | Cost      | Geography                     | Summoned magic                            |
|-------------------------|----------|-------------|-----------|-------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|
| Contact Karyatid        | 4        | N3          | 20 Nature | Forest                        | N3 in forest, N2 outside                  |
| Contact Oceanid         | 5        | W3          | 25 Water  | Not restricted in shown block | W3 plus three random picks from A/E/D/N/G |
| Contact Oreiad          | 6        | N4          | 30 Nature | Mountain or border mountain   | N3A2E1                                    |
| Contact Eleionomae      | 6        | W3          | 35 Water  | Swamp                         | W3D2A1                                    |
| Contact Nephelae        | 7        | W3A1        | 30 Water  | Not caves                     | A3W3                                      |
| Daughter of the Evening | 8        | S4          | 38 pearls | Ordinary land conditions      | S3A2, immortal                            |
| Summon Boread           | 8        | A3W2        | 45 Air    | Ordinary valid province       | Winged giant commander                    |

This is the heart of the overhaul. Geography becomes magic access.

## Unique and late summons

| Summon                  | Research      | Requirement | Cost      | Notes                              |
|-------------------------|---------------|-------------|-----------|------------------------------------|
| The Guardian of Hades   | Conjuration 6 | D4          | 20 Death  | Unique Kerberos                    |
| Summon Divine Hero      | Conjuration 7 | S5          | 40 pearls | One Divine Hero from national pool |
| Titan of War & Wisdom   | Conjuration 8 | S4E2        | 40 pearls | Unique Athena                      |
| Titan of the Seas       | Conjuration 8 | W4E2        | 40 Water  | Underwater only; unique Poseidon   |
| Titan of the Underworld | Conjuration 8 | D5          | 40 Death  | Unique Hades                       |
| The Scourge of the Deep | Conjuration 9 | W5N3        | 60 Water  | Underwater only; unique Cetus      |

## Other national summons

- Headless Men: N2, seven Nature gems, ten-plus Blemmyes; the school and research level are inherited from Summon Ogres.
- Sow Dragon Teeth and the unmodded Arcoscephalian national rituals remain relevant unless specifically overwritten elsewhere.

- The future-site lists also identify Spartae, Blemmyes, Lampads, Hound of Twilight, Keres, Keledone, Khalkotauros, Daimones, nymph commanders, Kerberos, and the three Titans as national summon products.

## National items

### Bag of Dragons Teeth

Source-confirmed:

- Construction 5;
- Earth level 2 through the copied Earth item;
- reduced item cost;
- summons three Spartae at battle start;
- grants one point of magic leadership;
- restricted to a group of appropriate nations including MA Arcoscephale.

It converts an E2 forge turn and Earth gems into a repeatable battlefield screen or reinforcement. The exact inherited base cost should be read from the final item card.

### Horoskopos

Source-confirmed:

- S2;
- cursed and not normally forgeable/found in the ordinary way;
- Luck;
- Morale +2;
- Inspirational 1;
- effects apply to the mount where relevant.

Its acquisition route is not established by the inspected item block. It should not be included in a routine forge plan until reproduced.

### Zodiac

Source-confirmed:

- Construction 5;
- S2;
- Astrologer-restricted item group;
- 50 points of bad-event prevention;
- Twist Fate;
- effects extend to mount.

The mod explicitly authorises Astrologers to use its restricted group. This turns selected Astrologers into provincial event-control assets without changing their magic.

## DE access ladders

### Reliable Nature-to-Air ladder

- 1 Recruit an N2 Archousa.
- 2 Obtain a named Nature booster to N3.



- 3 Cast Contact Karyatid in a forest.
- 4 Use the N3 Karyatid in forest, with a booster to N4 if required.
- 5 Cast Contact Oreiad on a mountain.
- 6 Receive an N3A2E1 Oreiad.
- 7 Use Air boosters, empowerment, or another summon to reach higher Air.

Every step requires the relevant research, gems, item, and geography. The ladder is powerful because it is reproducible; it is not instantaneous.

### Water-to-Death ladder

- 1 Preserve a W2 Mystic.
- 2 Add a named Water booster to reach W3 for ritual casting.
- 3 Cast Contact Eleionomae in a swamp.
- 4 Receive W3D2A1.
- 5 Use Death boosters, empowerment, or further summons to reach D4.
- 6 Cast The Guardian of Hades or other Death nationals.

Contact Oceanid is an alternate W3 route with random Death, Glamour, Nature, Air, or Earth outcomes. Because the Oceanid randoms are variable, it is a portfolio rather than deadline guarantee.

### Astral-to-Air ladder

- 1 Recruit an S4 Astrologer or boost S3.
- 2 At Conjuraton 8, cast Daughter of the Evening.
- 3 Receive an immortal S3A2 commander.
- 4 Use Air boosters or combine with Water access.
- 5 Reach A3W2 for Summon Boread or other Air operations.

### Constellation ladder

Astrologer randoms can naturally provide:

- S4F1 for Aries;
- S4W1 for Cetus;
- S4E1 for Taurus.

Because the fixed and rare randoms interact, exact probabilities should be computed from the current Astrologer distribution and verified after the mod is loaded. S6 for Libra requires boosters or another high-Astral route.

## DE research priorities

The mod creates two new trunks.

### Constellation trunk

- immediate Zodiac Cascades provides an early fatigue tool;
- Conjuraton 4 gives the ordinary Northern Star and the research neighbourhood for Aries if the copied school remains;
- levels 5-7 progressively add Cetus, Taurus, and Libra;
- the chosen constellation must fit the army and enemy because only one light can operate.

## Nymph trunk

- level 4 Karyatid begins the Nature ladder;
- level 5 Oceanid begins the Water-random ladder;
- level 6 Oreiad and Eleionomae open Air and Death;
- level 7 Nephelae and Divine Heroes expand force;
- level 8 Daughter of Evening and Titans establish late magic.

The best branch depends on gems and terrain. Researching Contact Oreiad without an N4 caster and a mountain produces no immediate capacity.

## DE army identity

The new roster supports a more mobile combined-arms formation:

- cheaper improved Hoplites;
- fast Hypaspists;
- offensive Phalangites;
- cheap Prodromoi;
- capital Hetairoi;
- paired sacreds;
- elephants and chariots;
- constellation-enhanced Mystics.

The nation can now create:

- a mobile Map Move 16 cavalry and infantry wing;
- a slower sacred or Hoplite core;
- Astral fatigue operations;
- nature-spirit and elemental commander support;
- late unique-summon armies.

Mixed movement must still be audited. One slow unit can reduce the route of an otherwise mobile force.

# Part XI: Divinitus 1.15.3 DE and the Grand Hierophant

## Layer boundary

Divinitus does not rewrite MA Arcoscephale's ordinary national roster in the inspected source. It rewrites Pretenders and adds event-driven powers.

The relevant national interaction is:

Dominions Enhanced national overhaul  
+ Divinitus Pretender choice  
= combined MA Arcoscephale

The strongest documented interaction is the Grand Hierophant, monster 3053.

## Combined object inheritance

Dominions Enhanced first rewrites the Grand Hierophant with:

- S2;
- path cost 20;
- base Pretender cost 30;
- HP 10, MR 18, and human item slots;
- 50 points of bad-event prevention;
- Disease Resistance 100.

Divinitus loads afterward and sets:

- base Pretender cost 150;
- all known non-priest magic paths +1 through `#magicboost 53 1`;
- bad-event prevention 75;
- Disease Resistance 100;
- the anointing, teaching, and site-search description and events.

Because Divinitus does not clear magic or reset the path cost in this block, the earlier DE S2 and path-cost values remain in the combined object unless another later command changes them. This is a load-order conclusion and should be confirmed in the Pretender screen.

## Paths known +1

The Grand Hierophant adds one effective level to known non-priest paths.

Strategic consequences:

- purchased path thresholds may be one level easier;
- battlefield and ritual access must be calculated from effective, not merely purchased, paths;
- bless path requirements and design costs must still use the Pretender interface's actual rules;
- path loss, transformation, and boosters require live verification.

The phrase does not mean the Pretender knows every path. It boosts paths that are known.

## Mystic anointing

The source event:

- requires the Grand Hierophant as god;
- targets a Mystic or Erytheian Mystic;
- requires a temple;
- adds Holy;
- transforms the target into monster 382, the Mystic Prophet;
- is hidden from the event log.

The mod description states that one Mystic at a temple is anointed each month, becoming H1 and sacred.

## Strategic uses

Anointed Mystics can potentially provide:

- sacred researchers;
- H1 communion participants;

- temple builders and preachers;
- bless access in battle;
- priest support without Archousa recruitment;
- targets for the teaching event.

## Operational requirement

Maintain:

- at least one eligible Mystic in a temple province;
- enough temple coverage to place trainees without disrupting the front;
- a record of which Mystic random is being transformed;
- a protected training hub.

## Test pending

The exact preservation of:

- random magic paths;
- experience;
- items;
- age;
- orders;
- recruitment identity;
- prophet interactions

must be reproduced through the transformation.

## Teaching deeper mysteries

The source event for Mystic Prophets:

- requires the Grand Hierophant in the same province;
- requires positive dominion;
- uses `#req_domchance 5`;
- checks the target's Astral threshold through `#req_targnopath3 4`;
- adds +1 Fire, Water, Earth, and Astral simultaneously.

The description expresses this as candles times 5% chance and a maximum of three.

## Probability

If `#req_domchance 5` behaves as described, the monthly success chance at  $\backslash(c)$  friendly candles is:

$\backslash[ p = 0.05c \backslash]$

| Candles | Monthly chance |
|---------|----------------|
| 1       | 5%             |
| 3       | 15%            |
| 5       | 25%            |
| 7       | 35%            |
| 10      | 50%            |

The probability of at least one success after  $n$  eligible months is:

$$1 - (1 - 0.05)^n$$

At five candles, six eligible months give:

$$1 - 0.75^6 \approx 82.2\%$$

## Path consequence

One success turns a typical Mystic Prophet into a much broader caster. Repeated success can create:

- multi-element communion masters;
- ritual cross-paths otherwise impossible in vanilla;
- high independent casters;
- forgers who compress several national roles.

## Source discrepancy

The prose says paths rise to a maximum of three. The event block visibly gates on an Astral-path condition and then boosts all four paths. A Mystic beginning at F2S1 could, under a literal reading of the commands, receive two successful boosts before Astral reaches three, potentially producing F4.

This is not asserted as engine behaviour. It is a high-priority controlled test because:

- command semantics may cap the other paths;
- transformation may alter the starting paths;
- the event requirement may behave differently from the literal reading;
- another hidden engine rule may enforce the prose maximum.

Until tested, the public doctrine uses the stated cap of three and records elemental over-cap as test pending.

## Site-search treasure

The source event:

- requires the Grand Hierophant;
- requires the Site Searching order on land;
- requires positive dominion;
- uses candles times 5% chance;
- grants 150 gold;
- grants 1d6 of each elemental gem.

"Elemental" means Fire, Air, Water, and Earth in the mod description.

## Conditional value

On success, expected gem gain is:

$$4 \times E(1d6) = 4 \times 3.5 = 14$$

At  $c$  candles, ignoring caps or event interactions, expected monthly value is:

$$E(\text{gold}) = 150(0.05^c) = 7.5^c$$

$$E(\text{total elemental gems}) = 14(0.05^c) = 0.7^c$$

| Candles | Expected gold / search month | Expected total elemental gems / search month |
|---------|------------------------------|----------------------------------------------|
| 1       | 7.5                          | 0.7                                          |
| 3       | 22.5                         | 2.1                                          |
| 5       | 37.5                         | 3.5                                          |
| 7       | 52.5                         | 4.9                                          |
| 10      | 75                           | 7                                            |

These are expected values, not guaranteed yields.

## Opportunity cost

The Grand Hierophant's search month could instead be:

- researching;
- forging;
- casting a ritual;
- moving;
- joining a battle;
- teaching at a different hub;
- preaching or performing another Pretender task.

Site searching is attractive when:

- friendly dominion is high;
- unsearched provinces remain;
- elemental gems unlock immediate DE summon or battle packages;
- the Pretender is not needed on the front.

It is unattractive when the expected treasure does not beat the deadline value of another order.

## Training-hub doctrine

A Grand Hierophant training province should contain:

- temple;
- laboratory;
- strong friendly dominion;
- eligible Mystic Prophet;
- guards and fortification;
- no unnecessary exposed gem stock;
- access to the front through a safe route.

The hub converts time into exceptional mages. It also concentrates the Pretender and valuable Mystics into an obvious remote and conventional target.

Security includes:

- dome consideration;
- patrols;
- scouts on adjacent provinces;
- reserve troops;
- an evacuation route;
- alternate laboratories;
- avoiding the capital if that creates one catastrophic target.

## Grand Hierophant strategic families

### Research-and-training family

Prioritises:

- high Magic scale;
- early Mystic production;
- temple network;
- protected training hub;
- ritual paths that trained Mystics can complement.

Risk:

- too much stationary investment;
- delayed first-war force;
- Pretender time consumed by teaching and searching.

### Elemental-treasure family

Prioritises:

- high dominion candles;
- systematic site searching;
- DE elemental summon ladder;
- rapid conversion of found gems.

Risk:

- expected-value variance;
- Pretender absent from critical operations;
- gathering gems without research or casters to spend them.

### Battlefield-hierophant family

Prioritises:

- combat paths and survivability;
- trained Mystics as battlefield masters;
- healing support;
- an awakening timed for war.

Risk:

- sacrificing the mod's unique economic and training effects;
- exposing the central Pretender and training engine.

### Ritual-platform family

Prioritises:

- paths missing after accounting for DE summon ladders;
- legendary ritual thresholds;
- booster and forge plan;
- imprisoned or dormant timing if the recruitable state can survive.

Risk:

- paying for paths the DE nymph ladder would have supplied more cheaply;
- planning rituals before the gem economy exists.

## Part XII: Combined-Mod Strategy

---

### What the combined ruleset changes

The combined nation has three compounding engines:

- 1 cheaper and broader combined-arms recruitment;
- 2 DE's national constellation and nymph summon ladder;
- 3 Divinitus Grand Hierophant training and treasure.

This creates exceptional upside but also severe attention demands.

The player must track:

- Mystic randoms;
- anointed status;
- training history;
- geography for summons;
- national spell research;
- constellation compatibility;
- multiple gem colours;
- hero and unique availability;
- ordinary fronts and Thrones.

### Combined opening priorities

A coherent opening selects one primary engine.

#### Military opening

- use improved Hoplites, Hypaspists, Phalangites, cavalry, and elephants;
- build forts;
- keep Grand Hierophant support secondary until borders stabilise.

#### Mystic training opening

- prioritise temple and Mystic production;
- accept a slower mundane expansion only if tests prove it;
- protect the training centre;
- research spells that make the first enhanced Mystics immediately useful.

#### Summon-ladder opening

- secure forest, mountain, and swamp provinces;
- reach the relevant Conjunction levels;
- preserve N2 and W2 specialists;
- use Grand Hierophant treasure to finance elemental bottlenecks.



Attempting all three at maximum speed is likely to produce too few troops, too few forts, and half-completed research.

## Combined magic compression

A trained Mystic can receive simultaneous F/W/E/S growth. DE then offers:

- constellation spells requiring S plus an element;
- elemental and Nature summons;
- national items;
- high Astral hero and Titan rituals.

This compresses jobs that would otherwise require several masters.

Potential trained roles include:

- S4F1 Aries caster;
- S4W1 Cetus caster;
- S4E1 Taurus caster;
- E2S2 Keledone ritual caster;
- F3E3 Brass Bull caster;
- W3 ritual caster for Oceanid or Eleionomae;
- broad independent Power of the Spheres caster.

Each role must be checked against:

- actual post-training paths;
- ritual versus battle restrictions;
- boosters;
- research;
- gem stock;
- whether using the mage consumes an irreplaceable training product.

## Combined path priorities

The Pretender should avoid buying paths that the nation can obtain reliably and cheaply through DE unless timing justifies them.

### More valuable Pretender paths

- paths required before summon ladders mature;
- paths that unlock national rituals with no cheap bridge;
- paths supporting an awake expansion role;
- paths needed for a specific global or legendary ritual;
- paths that improve blessings used by a meaningful sacred roster.

### Less valuable redundant purchases

- high Nature bought solely to reach N3 when N2 Archousai plus a booster can begin the ladder;
- high Air bought solely for eventual access when Oreiads and Daughters can supply it in time;
- broad elements bought without a ritual, battlefield, bless, or forging job.

Redundancy can still be worth paying for when it removes a deadline or geography dependency.

## Combined counter surfaces

The combined nation can be attacked through:

- temple and training-hub destruction;
- capital pressure against Astrologers and unique site troops;
- raids on forests, mountains, and swamps required for summons;
- gem denial;
- assassination of trained Mystics;
- communion clears;
- anti-Astral Magic Duel tactics;
- resistance to the chosen constellation;
- simultaneous fronts that overload attention.

The correct defence is not a larger single army. It is redundancy across:

- temples;
- labs;
- trained casters;
- access routes;
- gem stores;
- battlefield packages.

## Part XIII: Controlled Tests

### Test standard

Every test record should include:

- Dominions version;
- mod names, versions, and load order;
- game settings;
- nation and Pretender;
- turn and province;
- relevant units, paths, items, gems, and scripts;
- expected result;
- observed result;
- replay or save identifier;
- whether the result was repeated;
- conclusion and confidence.

Change one major variable at a time.

### Test 1: Mystic random distribution

Question: Does the current unmodded and modded Mystic use the documented guaranteed FWES roll plus independent 50% F/W/E rolls?

Method:

- 1 Recruit at least 128 Mystics under unmodded 6.35.
- 2 Record exact F/W/E/S paths.
- 3 Compare F2, W2, E2, and S2 frequencies with 12.5%, 12.5%, 12.5%, and 25%.

- 4 Confirm no E2S2 or double-elemental-2 result appears.
- 5 Repeat with DE 2.16.
- 6 Repeat with both mods.

Purpose: detect current-data or mod inheritance errors, not prove random fairness from a small sample.

## Test 2: Astrologer rare random

Question: Does the 10% extra random operate independently and can it produce S5 or an elemental level 2?

Method:

- 1 Recruit a large Astrologer sample in a debug or long test.
- 2 Record S3/S4/S5 and elemental results.
- 3 Compare with the derived 73.125%, 26.25%, and 0.625% Astral distribution.
- 4 Repeat under DE.

## Test 3: Starting-army expansion

Question: Which independent classes can the starting twenty Peltasts and twenty Hoplites defeat with acceptable losses?

Method:

- 1 Use fixed settings and no combat Pretender.
- 2 Test ordinary infantry, barbarians, heavy cavalry, crossbows, and heavy infantry.
- 3 Vary only formation and orders.
- 4 Record body losses, commander safety, battle duration, and next-turn readiness.

## Test 4: Elephant package sizing

Question: How many elephants and screening bodies produce reliable expansion under the chosen independent strength?

Method:

- 1 Test several small counts rather than one large army.
- 2 Use identical target classes.
- 3 Record routs, friendly trample, elephant wounds, and economic replacement.
- 4 Compare screen types.
- 5 Repeat under DE because ordinary troop performance changes.

## Test 5: Chariot versus elephant

Question: Against which targets does the cheaper chariot produce a better gold and attrition result than the elephant?

Method:

- compare equal gold values;
- test light infantry, archers, heavy infantry, and large units;
- record total package survival, not only mounts.

## Test 6: Hoplite versus Hypaspist

Question: When do three extra Protection points outperform Defence, Morale, movement, and lower resources?

Method:

- equal gold;
- equal resources;
- equal frontage;
- low-damage swarm;
- high-damage infantry;
- giants;
- armour-destruction support;
- long fatigue battle.

Repeat under vanilla and DE, where both units change materially.

## Test 7: Formation density

Question: How do formation fighters perform under area damage and frontage pressure?

Method:

- dense versus ordinary formation;
- equal troop count;
- melee-only opponent;
- area evocation opponent;
- fatigue-cloud opponent;
- trample opponent.

Record contact timing, attacks delivered, casualties by square, and rout timing.

## Test 8: Independent casting versus communion

Question: At what battle size does a communion outperform the same number of independent Mystics?

Method:

- 1 Select a single enemy army and research level.
- 2 Test eight independent Mystics.
- 3 Test four slaves and four masters.
- 4 Test six slaves and two masters.
- 5 Equalise gems.
- 6 Record useful casts, fatigue, slave wounds, enemy kills, and mage survival.

## Test 9: Communion collapse

Question: Which master scripts overload two-, four-, and eight-slave communions?

Method:

- record each master path before and after communion;
- use exact five-spell scripts;

- test battle lengths beyond the script;
- remove one slave through controlled damage;
- observe threshold loss and fatigue cascade.

## Test 10: Shared self-buffs

Question: Which Mystic master self-buffs are shared with slaves and how do they change fatigue relationships?

Method:

- Power of the Spheres;
- Phoenix Power;
- Summon Earthpower;
- personal resistance and protection spells;
- compare slave effective paths and fatigue before and after.

## Test 11: Magic Duel policy

Question: How does enemy low-S duel pressure affect S2 Mystics and S3-S5 Astrologers?

Method:

- one opposing duellist per target class;
- repeated trials;
- record deaths and surviving caster value;
- compare independent deployment and communion.

## Test 12: Mind Hunt and healing

Question: How valuable is national healing after failed or detected Mind Hunts?

Method:

- S4 Astrologer against provinces with and without enemy Astral;
- record feeblemind, death, and other outcomes;
- move survivors to Hieria and Archousa provinces;
- record recovery time and failures.

## Test 13: Scrying and glamour

Question: What exact information does automatic dominion scrying reveal in 6.35?

Method:

- ordinary army;
- glamourous units;
- stealth units;
- hidden commander;
- fort construction;
- adjacent and same-province dominion states;
- disciple partner view.

Compare with scout, spy, and ritual scrying reports.

## Test 14: Hiereia outside-fort recruitment

Question: Which province types and structures allow Hiereia recruitment under vanilla and DE?

Method:

- every land terrain;
- with and without fort;
- with and without lab;
- with and without temple;
- record recruitment interface and requirements.

## Test 15: Healing allocation

Question: How are Healing 1 and Healing 3 attempts allocated among multiple afflicted units?

Method:

- identical afflicted units;
- mixed affliction severity;
- ordinary, sacred, mounted, magic-being, undead, and inanimate cases;
- repeat over enough months to distinguish impossibility from variance.

## Test 16: DE paired Heart Companions

Question: When and how does one 9322 recruitment become two unit-747 Heart Companions?

Method:

- recruit at Tower and Gymnasium;
- observe recruitment queue, arrival, seasonal shape, event timing, upkeep, experience, and squad assignment;
- verify whether both bodies receive bless and equipment changes;
- test losses before and after transformation.

## Test 17: DE inherited unit cards

Question: What are the final costs and inherited attributes of Hetairoi, Hipparchus, and other copied objects?

Method:

- capture full live unit cards;
- compare with copied vanilla source object;
- record every explicit override;
- verify rider and mount separately.

## Test 18: DE constellation exclusivity

Question: How do Aries, Cetus, Taurus, Libra, and Light of the Northern Star replace or block each other?

Method:

- cast each alone;

- cast two in both orders;
- use opposing Arcoscephalian casters;
- inspect path boosts, battlefield effects, duration, and message log.

## Test 19: DE summon geography

Question: Which terrain flags satisfy forest, swamp, mountain, border mountain, cave, and underwater restrictions?

Method:

- test every nymph ritual in each plausible terrain combination;
- test fortified and unfortified provinces;
- test alternate planes;
- record ritual availability before spending gems.

## Test 20: Oceanid randoms

Question: Does `#custommagic 29952 300` produce three independent picks from Air, Earth, Death, Nature, and Glamour as expected?

Method:

- summon a statistically useful sample;
- record duplicates and maxima;
- compare access probabilities;
- identify deadline-safe and portfolio-only outcomes.

## Test 21: Grand Hierophant inheritance

Question: Under DE then Divinitus, what are the final S path, path cost, base cost, item slots, bad-event prevention, and magic boost?

Method:

- inspect the Pretender selection screen;
- buy one level in several paths;
- create the Pretender;
- compare design display and in-game unit card;
- reverse the load order in a separate test to demonstrate why the supported order matters.

## Test 22: Mystic anointing

Question: Is an eligible Mystic anointed every month, and what survives transformation?

Method:

- one target at a temple;
- several targets at one temple;
- targets at several temples;
- no target;
- target carrying items;
- target with experience and a rare random;
- record selection, timing, and preserved attributes.

## Test 23: Grand Hierophant teaching cap

Question: Can an elemental path exceed three when an S1 Mystic begins with F2, W2, or E2?

Method:

- 1 Anoint a known F2S1 Mystic.
- 2 Place it with the Grand Hierophant in high dominion.
- 3 Repeat until two training successes or the event stops.
- 4 Record F and S after each success.
- 5 Repeat with S2 and ordinary elemental starting paths.

This directly resolves the prose-versus-event ambiguity.

## Test 24: Site-search treasure

Question: Does the event chance equal candles times 5%, and does 1d6vis 51 grant one separate d6 of F/A/W/E?

Method:

- repeat searches at several candle values;
- record ordinary discovered sites separately;
- record event gold and each gem colour;
- compare success frequencies and conditional dice distribution;
- test provinces already fully searched.

## Test 25: Combined trained caster roles

Question: Which trained Mystic thresholds can be reached before a realistic first or second war?

Method:

- run full turn-20 and turn-30 economies;
- include temples, forts, labs, research, troop recruitment, and Pretender orders;
- record number and quality of trained Mystics;
- field one complete constellation or ritual package;
- compare against a military-first opening.

# Part XIV: Essays

## Essay I: The Nation Dossier as a Reproducible Argument

A nation guide is an argument about conversion. It begins with rules, claims that certain capacities follow, and recommends decisions intended to turn those capacities into victory. Like any argument, it can fail because a premise is false, a step is missing, or the conclusion exceeds the evidence.

The most common false premise is stale data. A guide remembers a gold cost, random path, spell level, or bless from another patch or another age. The prose may remain persuasive because the strategic vocabulary still sounds familiar. Yet the actual nation now recruits a different unit, pays a different opportunity cost, or cannot reach the claimed path. Version labels are not editorial decoration. They define the object being discussed.



The most common missing step is access. A national ritual is listed, so the writer says the nation can cast it. A mage reaches one of its paths, so the other path is assumed to appear through "boosters." A communion reaches a battlefield threshold, so the same elevated mage is imagined casting a ritual next month. These statements collapse distinct systems. Rituals do not ordinarily borrow battlefield communion levels. Boosters require research, paths, gems, item slots, and forge turns. A hero may never arrive. A summon may require terrain the nation does not own.

The most common excessive conclusion is the universal build. A design succeeds on one map against one field and becomes "best." But an awake expander, imprisoned scales build, and ritual platform purchase time in different currencies. One survives a rush, one compounds behind space, and one accesses effects after research. None can be evaluated without the expected deadline.

A reproducible dossier exposes every bridge. It says which unit casts the spell, which random produces the unit, how likely the random is, which item supplies the missing level, when the item can be forged, where the army assembles, which gem carrier accompanies it, and what happens if the opponent presents another defence.

This precision does not eliminate judgment. It improves judgment by showing where it enters. "The manual gives the Hoplite Protection 18" is a rule claim. "Hoplites are preferable to Hypaspists here" is doctrine based on enemy damage, resources, movement, and morale. Another player can disagree with the choice while accepting the data. That is productive disagreement.

Tests complete the argument. Expansion claims are played to turn 12 with real infrastructure. Communion scripts are allowed to continue after the fifth spell. Random distributions are sampled. Modded objects are read after load order. A battle replay is not used merely to announce victory; it is used to see contact timing, target selection, fatigue, and the first point of failure.

The finished dossier is neither a recipe nor a plain encyclopaedia entry. It connects verified facts to conditional plans, with a method for correcting each one when the situation changes.

## Essay II: Arcoscephale and the Conversion of Knowledge

Arcoscephale's most distinctive resource is not Astral pearls or heavy infantry. It is the ability to turn information into tailored force.

Automatic scrying inside dominion gives the kingdom unusually good reports where it is politically strongest. Mystics then provide a probabilistic library of Fire, Water, Earth, and Astral tools. Astrologers deepen Astral. The combination invites a particular form of play: observe the approaching force, classify its defences, and assemble the appropriate package.

This promise is easy to exaggerate. Seeing an army does not defeat it. A report can reveal heavy infantry, but the E2 Mystic needed for Destruction may be in another laboratory. The research may be one level short. The Earth gems may be carried by a commander marching elsewhere. The only road may be blocked. Knowledge has strategic value only when the state can deliver the response before the deadline.

This is why fort distribution matters. Each fort supplies Research Points, another draw from the Mystic distribution, and another place from which a response cell can move. A larger mage portfolio reduces variance. A distributed laboratory network reduces distance. A gem reserve cuts preparation time. Scouts beyond dominion extend the warning horizon.

The same system explains the danger of losing a field army. An Arcoscephalian army often carries years of stored options: rare randomnesses, Astral pearls, boosters, and communion slaves that were also researchers. When destroyed, the loss is not measured only in battlefield gold. The nation loses

response branches. An opponent who kills the E2 and S4 specialists may invalidate spells that remain fully researched.

Knowledge also has diplomatic value. Accurate reports discourage weak raids and reveal concentration. They allow credible warnings to allies and more reliable estimates of whether a neighbour is honouring a border. Yet information can make a player overconfident. Scrying inside dominion creates a sharp boundary: the interior feels visible, the exterior does not. Stealth, magic movement, and remote attacks exploit that comfort.

A mature Arcoscephalian state treats information as a chain:

```
report
-> classification
-> response choice
-> caster and gem assignment
-> movement
-> battle evidence
-> revised classification
```

The final step matters. A report predicts. A battle replay teaches. The nation that learns faster eventually needs fewer mages and gems to solve the same problem.

## Essay III: Mystics, Probability, and Doctrine

The Mystic appears broad because any recruit can display several paths. The strategic reality is more exact. Every Mystic begins with S1, gains one guaranteed roll among Fire, Water, Earth, and Astral, then receives separate fifty-percent chances in each element. This creates abundance and constraint at the same time.

The abundance is obvious. Five of eight Mystics know any named element. More than one in five know all three. Every one can participate in an Astral communion. Several forts quickly produce a catalogue of point buffs, self-buffs, evocations, control spells, and forging cross-paths.

The constraint lies in doubled paths. F2, W2, and E2 each appear only one time in eight. E2S2 cannot occur naturally because the same guaranteed roll would have to be both Earth and Astral. Two elements cannot both reach level two on the same recruit. A strategy that remembers only the broad catalogue will eventually promise an impossible mage.

Probability changes recruitment doctrine. A one-in-eight result has an expected waiting time of eight recruits, but expectation is not a delivery date. After eight recruits there remains more than a one-third chance that no such specialist has appeared. A state that needs E2 for the first war must recruit from several forts, maintain an alternate branch, or use another access route.

Probability also changes the meaning of an individual mage. An F2 Mystic is more than a stronger F1. It is one of the nation's limited natural bridges to Phoenix Power, high Fire evocation, and particular forging paths. Assigning it as a communion slave may be correct, but the decision should be deliberate. The same body can serve as a researcher, master, ritual candidate, or battlefield caster, and those roles compete.

This competition explains why communions should be designed from spell packages rather than habit. Four slaves can raise a common F1 master to F3, but those four slaves could also have cast four independent Astral or elemental spells. The communion wins when path elevation and fatigue distribution produce effects that the independent group cannot match. It loses when the battle is small, the target can be solved by low magic, or enemy area attacks make concentration fatal.

The expert skill is not memorising every possible Mystic. It is managing a portfolio:

- label rare results;
- protect deadline-critical specialists;
- keep alternate branches;
- calculate at-least-one probabilities;
- compare independent and communal output;
- preserve enough researchers that victory today does not erase research tomorrow.

Under Divinitus, the Grand Hierophant can change the distribution after recruitment by teaching several paths at once. Portfolio thinking still matters because training introduces another scarce resource: time in high dominion with the Pretender present. The question is not only which Mystic arrived, but which one deserves the next training opportunity.

## Essay IV: Healing, Intelligence, and the Preservation of Force

Arcoscephale possesses two advantages that are easy to undervalue because neither directly kills an enemy: healing and automatic scrying. Together they improve force preservation.

Healing converts survivors into future capacity. A wounded elephant, Astrologer, combat Pretender, or thug may carry an affliction whose cost exceeds the hit points already restored. A damaged eye reduces precision. A crippled leg ruins movement. Feeblemind can remove a mage from useful service. Concentrated healers create a place where those losses can sometimes be reversed.

The useful economic comparison is not the healer's monthly wage against one cured affliction. It is the value of the unit's remaining lifetime. Restoring a rare S4 Astrologer may recover remote-magic and ritual access that would take many capital turns to replace. Restoring an ordinary Peltast is worth less. Healing allocation still has a strategic side even when the engine selects targets automatically, because players decide which units gather in the province and how long they remain.

Scrying reduces the wounds that need healing. Seeing the enemy approach allows the nation to avoid presenting elephants to fear, Mystics to flyers, or Hoplites to armour destruction. It permits the correct reserve to move before contact. It also allows damaged units to withdraw through safer routes.

Neither system eliminates risk. Healing cannot restore the dead and may not cure the desired affliction immediately. Scrying does not reveal every stealth or magic-phase threat and only functions where dominion supplies the view. Overreliance produces predictable failures: the combat Pretender attacks because "the priestesses will heal it," or the capital is left open because "scrying sees everything."

Preservation requires a full cycle:

```
observe threat
-> choose favourable engagement
-> protect valuable bodies
-> win with survivors
-> withdraw damaged assets
-> heal and reassign
```

The final word is reassign. A recovered unit should return to the role its current body and strategic value justify. A once-wounded elephant may rejoin expansion. A recovered Mind Hunter may return to a rear laboratory. A Pretender healed after a narrow victory may be more valuable forging or deterring than repeating the same gamble.

## Essay V: From Classical Army to Astral State

The visual identity of Middle Age Arcoscephale is classical warfare: spear lines, bronze, chariots, and elephants. The strategic identity is a transition away from dependence on those bodies.

In the first year, ordinary troops seize the economy. Hoplites absorb common weapons. Hypaspists move and defend. Peltasts and Cardaces provide affordable frontage. Elephants transform favourable size matchups into rapid routs. The army is not obsolete; it is the instrument that buys time and provinces.

Research changes what the army means. Earth magic can harden it or destroy the enemy's armour. Astral can make key squares ethereal, paralyse elites, or attack minds. Fire and Water can kill dense formations. Communion turns modest randomness into specialists. At this stage the troops are still combatants, but their greater function is to create time and targets for magic.

Later, the relation reverses. The mage state is the scarce offensive core. Troops screen it, hold forts, absorb attacks, provide siege bodies, and claim territory after remote or battlefield magic has broken resistance. A player who continues measuring strength only by the number of elephants will misread the nation.

This transition creates a tension. The old army is expensive in resources and attention; the Astral state is expensive in gold, laboratories, pearls, and mage-turns. Investing too early in magic produces a small realm that can research but not survive. Investing too long in troops produces a large realm that cannot answer modern counters.

The transition point is not a turn number. It arrives when:

- the next troop purchase adds less capability than the next Mystic;
- a research node defeats a class the army cannot;
- borders stabilise enough for forts to compound;
- enemy magic begins invalidating unbuffered troops;
- a siege or Throne operation requires more than field bodies.

Dominions Enhanced makes the transition richer rather than removing it. Cheaper and more mobile troops extend mundane relevance, while constellations, nymph summons, and Titans create a larger magical destination. Divinitus adds trained Mystics who can embody several elements at once. The classical army does not disappear. It becomes the territorial shell of an increasingly supernatural state.

## Essay VI: Geography as a Magic Path

Under Dominions Enhanced, forest, mountain, swamp, and water access become part of Arcoscephale's mage roster.

An N2 Archousa is not yet an Oreiad caster. She needs a Nature booster and a forest to contact a Karyatid. The Karyatid is strongest in forest and can help reach N4. N4 plus a mountain produces an Oreiad, which opens Air and Earth. A W3 caster in a swamp produces an Eleionomae with Death and Air. An S4 Astrologer eventually calls an immortal Daughter of Evening with Air.

The map contains latent paths. A nearby forest may be worth more than its income because it begins the Nature ladder. A swamp can become the nation's first reliable Death bridge. A mountain supports Oreiad contact and conjunction rituals. An underwater foothold enables Titans and the Scourge of the Deeps.

This changes expansion and diplomacy. Terrain is no longer valued only by income, resources, and fort geometry. A treaty that cedes the only safe swamp may also cede Death access. A raid that interrupts the mountain laboratory can delay the entire constellation or nymph programme. A fort built on the correct terrain protects a magical production node.

Geographic access has a cost: it is visible and contestable. A Pretender path travels with the Pretender. A terrain ladder depends on holding the province, building or preserving a laboratory, moving the caster, and surviving the ritual month. Opponents can read the same map and attack the bridge.

The expert response is to record terrain in the access ledger:

```
N2 Archousa
+ Nature booster
+ forest laboratory
+ Conjunction 4
+ 20 Nature gems
= Karyatid
```

This notation makes two things clear. First, the access is real. Second, every component can be delayed or denied.

## Part XV: Reference Checklists

### Vanilla quick doctrine

- Expand with tested infantry, elephant, chariot, or Pretender packages.
- Budget the 300-gold laboratory with every fort.
- Recruit Mystics widely; record every random.
- Treat E2, W2, F2, and S4+ as portfolio assets.
- Use communions only when path elevation beats independent casting.
- Preserve the capital Astrologer pipeline.
- Use scrying as one layer of intelligence.
- Use Hiereiiai outside forts and Archousai for concentrated healing.
- Bridge missing paths deliberately.
- Convert field victories into forts, laboratories, and Thrones.

### DE quick doctrine

- Recalculate the entire roster; do not use vanilla cost assumptions.
- Use cheaper improved infantry and new cavalry for mobility.
- Treat paired Heart Companions as a separate sacred economy.
- Exploit N2 Archousai.
- Secure forest, mountain, swamp, and water nodes.
- Choose one constellation per battle.
- Plan the nymph ladder from caster, booster, gem, research, and terrain.
- Protect unique summons and heroes.
- Capture live cards for inherited mod objects.

## Divinitus quick doctrine

- Confirm the final Grand Hierophant in the Pretender screen.
- Build temples where anointing can occur safely.
- Record which Mystic is transformed.
- Train in strong dominion.
- Compare teaching, site searching, research, forging, and war orders.
- Do not assume the stated path cap until tested.
- Convert elemental treasure into immediate packages.
- Protect the training hub without concentrating every irreplaceable asset there.

## Source register

### Official

- Dominions 6 Manual, revision 2:
- Scouting and Scrying;
- Healing and afflictions;
- Communion;
- spell and ritual tables;
- MA Arcoscephale national summary and roster;
- national spells and rituals.

### Supplied mod sources

- DomEnhanced2\_16.dm
- MA Arcoscephale unit definitions 9316-9323;
- vanilla monster rewrites;
- national sites;
- nation 50 recruitment block;
- national spells, items, heroes, and events.
- Divinitus\_1.15.3\_DE.dm
- Grand Hierophant rewrite;
- Mystic anointing;
- teaching events;
- site-search treasure event.

### Current structured and community cross-checks

- Dominions 6 Mod Inspector, maintained by larzm42;
- Illwiki Dominions 6 MA Arcoscephale page;
- current and historical community discussion used only for doctrine and hypothesis.

Community claims are not used to override official or source-confirmed object definitions without a recorded current test.

## Open research ledger

The highest-priority unresolved questions are:

- 1 current live Mystic and Astrologer random display under 6.36;
- 2 exact scrying interaction with glamour and stealth;

- 3 reliable expansion party ranges;
- 4 independent casting versus communion break-even;
- 5 DE inherited unit and spell-card values;
- 6 paired Heart Companion timing;
- 7 constellation replacement behaviour;
- 8 nymph custom-magic distributions;
- 9 Grand Hierophant combined inheritance;
- 10 Mystic Prophet transformation preservation;
- 11 teaching cap semantics;
- 12 treasure-event probability and gem colours.

These questions are deliberately visible. The dossier is already usable, but it should become more precise as controlled evidence replaces provisional labels.

# Part XVI: Middle Age Marignon, Fiery Justice

## Marignon one-page command brief

Marignon begins as an armoured human kingdom backed by crossbows, sacred cavalry, cheap Fire apprentices, Astral-capable Witch Hunters, powerful priests, and a capital pipeline of Grand Masters. Its first transition is from ordinary steel into coordinated Fire and Astral battle magic. Its later transition is into angelic summons and stronger strategic magic.

The nation is strongest when it uses each layer for the job it actually performs:

- crossbows punish armour and force shields;
- cheap heavy infantry hold space and add siege bodies;
- Knights of the Chalice provide concentrated sacred force rather than affordable frontage;
- Witch Hunters turn ordinary forts into Fire-Astral war colleges;
- Grand Masters supply high paths, random Air or Earth access, and the best communion masters;
- Inquisitors and freely recruitable Friars turn dominion control into a campaign tool;
- Architects improve the fort network and shorten sieges;
- national angel rituals convert Conjuration research and Astral pearls into mobile sacred power.

The main limits are just as important. Marignon has no dependable native Water, Death, Nature, Blood, or Glamour. Its best mage is capital-only, expensive, and consumes four recruitment points. Much of the army wears enough armour to care about fatigue, armour destruction, and battlefield-wide elemental damage. A plan that only adds more heavy infantry eventually meets a counter it cannot out-armour.

## Marignon evidence and ruleset

The roster and national rules below use the revision-2 official manual. Grand Master randoms are resolved through the pinned 6.35 Inspector export: F3 S2 H2, one guaranteed level from Fire, Air, Earth, or Astral, plus an independent 10% second level from the same set. Advice is labelled strategy. Exact expansion counts remain test dependent because map strength, independent composition, scales, bless, formations, and commander quality change the result.

## Marignon conversion chain

```
crossbows, armour, and sacred cavalry  
-> safe expansion and defensible borders  
-> forts, laboratories, and Architects  
-> Witch Hunters at ordinary forts  
-> Fire-Astral battlefield packages  
-> Grand Master communions and boosters  
-> angels, remote reach, and Throne operations
```

The chain can break in three common places. Excess cavalry delays forts. Too many Initiates produce research without enough Astral organisers. Too many Grand Masters consume capital time and gold before the wider fort network can support them.



## National rules that shape the plan

| Rule                 | Practical consequence                                                                                                      |
|----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Order limit +1       | Marignon can lean further into Order when the economy and recruitment plan justify it.                                     |
| Bless points +3      | A useful sacred package does not require the Pretender to pay for every point alone.                                       |
| Inquisition          | Inquisitors remove enemy dominion and can spread friendly dominion up to one candle in owned provinces.                    |
| Friars outside forts | Priest coverage, preaching, and army leadership do not consume a fort commander slot everywhere.                           |
| Architects           | The capital can produce commanders that build better forts and provide +15 siege strength.                                 |
| Standard forts       | The nation still needs a deliberate fort-and-laboratory budget; the Architect improves the result but does not pay for it. |

Inquisition is not merely defensive flavour. It supports border conversion, weakens hostile dominion effects, and helps sacred forces operate under their own bless. It is still slower than winning the province and building infrastructure. Priests should support the campaign rather than replace it.

## Marignon roster by job

| Unit                  | Best job                                                     | Important limit                                                                                  |
|-----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Crossbowman           | Armour pressure, supporting fire, cheap ranged mass          | Ordinary precision and friendly-fire risk; needs a screen                                        |
| Pikeneer              | Anti-large line and repel pressure                           | Low Defence and ordinary damage when the length advantage is irrelevant                          |
| Halberdier            | Armour-piercing line damage and siege mass                   | Slow, heavily armoured, vulnerable to fatigue and missiles without shields                       |
| Swordsman             | General heavy infantry and high-damage strikes               | No shield and the same fatigue problem as the other heavy line troops                            |
| Man at Arms           | Better-defended line and bodyguard-quality infantry          | Higher gold, resources, and recruitment-point demand                                             |
| Flagellant            | Cheap sacred mass, patrol or siege body, disposable pressure | No armour, poor Defence, and losses can become expensive when the bless is overbuilt around them |
| Royal Guard           | Durable non-sacred cavalry and mobile reserve                | Very expensive in resources and recruitment points                                               |
| Knight of the Chalice | Sacred shock cavalry and decisive flank                      | Seventy gold, heavy resource and recruitment demand, and a mount that remains a separate target  |

The ordinary expansion army should normally combine a protected line with crossbows. Pikes are selected when large targets justify them. Great weapons are selected when armour is the problem. Sacred cavalry is used where the charge and survivability change the battle enough to justify its price. Mixing every unit into every party hides which piece is doing useful work.

## Marignon commander and mage portfolio

| Commander                   | Paths or ability              | Main jobs                                                               | Recruitment warning                                                                           |
|-----------------------------|-------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Initiate                    | F1                            | Cheap research, light Fire support, site searching                      | Two recruitment points for a narrow mage; do not let cheap gold cost hide the fort-turn cost  |
| Inquisitor                  | F1 H2, Inquisitor             | Dominion work, blessing, banishment, leadership                         | Better at religious operations than research efficiency                                       |
| Witch Hunter                | F2 S1 H1, Patrol +10          | Core researcher, communion member, Holy Pyre caster, patrol support     | Costs 260 gold and two recruitment points; field losses damage both research and war capacity |
| High Inquisitor             | F1 H3, Inquisitor             | Strong preaching, large blessings, claims, banishment                   | Capital-only and four recruitment points                                                      |
| Grand Master                | F3 S2 H2 plus FAES randoms    | High research, communion master, boosters, angels, high Fire and Astral | Capital-only, 520 gold, four recruitment points                                               |
| Architect                   | Mason, Siege +15              | Better forts, siege acceleration                                        | Capital commander turn competes directly with Grand Masters and High Inquisitors              |
| Friar                       | H1, recruitable outside forts | Cheap priest coverage and ordinary leadership                           | Not a replacement for a battle mage                                                           |
| Assassin, Scout, Troubadour | Stealth operations            | Information, commander pressure, deception                              | Outcomes are matchup dependent and can create diplomatic consequences                         |

### Reading the Grand Master random

The guaranteed random gives a nominal 25% result in Fire, Air, Earth, or Astral. The independent 10% second roll slightly raises the chance of seeing at least one chosen path to 26.875%. A double result in the same chosen path occurs only 0.625% of the time.

This produces several distinct assets:

- F4 reaches stronger Fire thresholds without a battlefield boost;
- S3 casts the first national angel ritual directly and improves Astral work;
- A1 opens Air searching and low-level utility, but it does not make Marignon a broad Air nation;
- E1 opens Earth searching and can begin an Earth booster or Summon Earthpower route;
- rare doubled results are bonuses, not requirements on which an opening should depend.

Every Grand Master should be labelled by random immediately. An unrecorded E1 or A1 roll can sit in a laboratory for years while the nation mistakenly plans around a path it believes it lacks.

### Marignon opening priorities

The opening has four simultaneous jobs:

- 1 expand with a tested infantry, crossbow, sacred, or Pretender package;
- 2 preserve enough gold and resources for the next fort;
- 3 begin recruiting Witch Hunters wherever laboratories exist;
- 4 use the capital on the scarce asset actually needed: Grand Master, Architect, High Inquisitor, or sacred cavalry.

The default capital choice is not automatically a Grand Master every month. An early Architect can create better long-term fort geometry. A High Inquisitor may be necessary for a Throne or dominion emergency. The correct capital queue follows the national bottleneck.

## Expansion packages to test

| Package                             | Intended target                             | Failure signal                                                                                       |
|-------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Armoured line plus crossbows        | Ordinary infantry and armoured independents | Fast flankers reach the crossbows or missile fire causes unacceptable friendly loss                  |
| Pikes plus supporting fire          | Large animals and cavalry                   | Small high-Defence troops ignore the length advantage and win the melee                              |
| Knight-led shock force              | Weak lines and exposed ranged troops        | Dense anti-large weapons, fatigue, or magic-resistant damage remove the expensive front              |
| Awake Pretender plus minimal escort | Rapid tempo and difficult early provinces   | The god is taking afflictions, being trapped, or delaying the economic design it was meant to enable |

No fixed troop count is presented as universal. The useful range comes from replaying the actual local independent types under the chosen scales and bless.

## Marignon research response tree

### Trunk: make Witch Hunters operational

Thaumaturgy 1  
-> Conjuraton 3  
-> Evocation 4

- Thaumaturgy 1 opens Communion Master and Communion Slave.
- Conjuraton 3 supplies Power of the Spheres for Astral casters and Phoenix Power for Fire casters.
- Evocation 4 opens the national Holy Pyre: an F2 armour-piercing area spell with a large base area, available to every Witch Hunter.

This is a real first-war package because an ordinary fort can recruit the caster. It still needs range, formation, gem, fatigue, and friendly-fire checks before battle.

### Branch A: heavier Fire and Astral fighting

Continue into Evocation 5 when Falling Fires, Stellar Cascades, or another current spell solves the observed enemy. Fire resistance can make a pure Fire branch poor. High-MR targets can reduce some Astral control packages. The army should carry at least two damage mechanisms rather than asking one school to defeat every defence.

### Branch B: protect the mundane army

Alteration 3 gives S1 Witch Hunters Body Ethereal and other defensive tools. Construction 2 and 4 open practical equipment and Earth support when the right Grand Master exists. This branch is strongest when ordinary troops are still winning contact but need help surviving the enemy's damage.

### Branch C: national angel ladder

| Research      | National ritual                         | Native route                                              |
|---------------|-----------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| Conjuration 5 | Contact Angel of the Host, S3, 7 pearls | S3 Grand Master or an S2 caster with a named boost        |
| Conjuration 6 | Angelic Choir, S3, 15 pearls            | Same S3 route; produces three H2 flying sacred mages      |
| Conjuration 6 | Contact Harbinger, S4, 25 pearls        | Higher Astral access; supplies an A3 H2 flying commander  |
| Conjuration 7 | Heavenly Wrath, S3 F1, 35 pearls        | S3 Grand Master already meets Fire                        |
| Conjuration 7 | Angelic Host, S5, 50 pearls             | Communion, boosters, or imported access                   |
| Conjuration 9 | Heavenly Choir, S7 F2, 144 pearls       | Endgame project, not an ordinary extension of the opening |

Contact Angel of the Host is the first clean conversion point. It turns a reachable S3 Grand Master and seven pearls into a flying sacred combat body. Contact Harbinger is an access project as much as a summon: its A3 H2 path line can widen Air magic and support mobile operations.

## Marignon battlefield packages

### Holy Pyre battery

- protected infantry establishes contact;
- crossbows punish armour before and during contact;
- Witch Hunters cast Holy Pyre from safe range;
- an Astral package protects or controls the most important squares;
- a reserve handles fire-resistant or highly mobile targets.

The spell is national, but the formation is not automatic. Large area can punish friendly troops if the battle line collapses into the target zone.

### Small communion

Use a small communion only when the path gain creates a named spell package. Count every master cast and every slave's relative path. Witch Hunters are expensive enough that disposable-slave doctrine can lose the research war even after winning one battle. Book V owns the fatigue and collapse arithmetic.

### Angel-supported mobile force

Flying angels solve movement and target-access problems that ordinary heavy infantry cannot. They still need intelligence, retreat routes, and enough conventional mass to hold what they take. A seven-pearl Angel of the Host should not be traded for trivial Province Defence merely because it flies.

## Marignon Pretender families

| Family                 | What it solves                                                        | What it must not conceal                                  |
|------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| Scales and path bridge | Economy, missing Nature/Death/Water/Blood/Glamour, high Astral or Air | A dormant or imprisoned bridge does not help an early war |

| Family                    | What it solves                                                | What it must not conceal                                                      |
|---------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Moderate sacred bless     | Knights and Flagellants without sacrificing the whole economy | The two sacred types have different bodies and failure modes                  |
| Awake expander            | Early tempo and difficult neutral provinces                   | Marignon already has expansion tools; the god must repay its opportunity cost |
| Angel and endgame enabler | S5-S7, stronger Air, globals, and ritual economy              | Researching the ritual is not the same as owning pearls and a safe caster     |

A durable, resistance-aware bless generally serves sacred cavalry more reliably than a narrow damage gimmick. Flagellants may value different effects because their main problem is surviving contact. The final design should test both bodies separately, including the sacred mounts.

## Marignon matchup and failure matrix

| Enemy problem                 | First answer to examine                                            | Avoid                                                |
|-------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| Heavy armour                  | Crossbows, great weapons, Holy Pyre, armour reduction              | Buying only more sword infantry                      |
| Fire resistance               | Astral control, mundane armour pressure, angels, imported paths    | Assuming F3-F4 automatically converts into damage    |
| Mass undead                   | Priests, H3 support, morale-safe formations, Fire where applicable | Sending expensive priests forward without screens    |
| Flyers and assassins          | Patrollers, bodyguards, dispersed command, protected mages         | One exposed communion master holding the entire plan |
| Armour destruction or fatigue | Wider spacing, ranged pressure, quicker battles, alternate troops  | Treating protection as permanent                     |
| High Magic Resistance         | Physical and Fire pressure, buffs, summons                         | Overcommitting to resistible single-target control   |

## Monthly Marignon audit

- Which capital asset is the current bottleneck?
- Is the next fort followed immediately by a laboratory and Witch Hunter queue?
- Are Grand Master randoms recorded?
- Can the first-war spell be cast by a repeatable mage?
- Does the army have a non-Fire answer?
- Are priests changing dominion where the army will actually fight?
- Are Knights of the Chalice earning more than their fort and resource cost?
- Is Conjuraton research attached to an affordable pearl budget?
- Which missing path is being solved by the Pretender, a summon, or an import?

## Marignon verification ledger

Open work remains narrow:

- 1 expansion ranges for each common independent class;
- 2 current live confirmation of the 6.35 Grand Master random display;
- 3 Holy Pyre targeting and friendly-fire formations across battlefield sizes;
- 4 small-communion fatigue budgets using Witch Hunters and Grand Masters;
- 5 angel package survival, upkeep, and return on pearl cost;
- 6 Architect timing versus repeated Grand Master recruitment;

- 7 DE and Divinitus changes kept in separate ruleset appendices.

# Part XVII: Middle Age Pyrène, Time of the Akelarre

## Pyrène one-page command brief

Pyrène combines unusually resilient human troops with mobile Air-Blood witches, blood-sacrificing priests, forest-recruitable Akerbeltz, cave recruits, and a capital sacred cavalry arm. The nation is not merely "Blood with knights." Its real advantage is distributed recruitment. Forests, caves, mountains, and ordinary forts can each add a different part of the state.

The opening should convert that geography into capacity:

- forts recruit the ordinary army, Sorginak, and Bishops;
- non-fort forests can recruit Akerbeltz;
- non-fort provinces can recruit path-random Pyrènian Monks;
- non-fort caves and the capital can recruit Bekryde scouts, leaders, and troops;
- the capital produces Emerald Knights and Emerald Counts;
- Blood and Nature then turn population, slaves, and terrain access into a growing magical economy.

The nation has clear weaknesses. Most human troops and leaders have Magic Resistance 9. The best sacred cavalry is capital-only and extremely resource intensive. Crossbows have Precision 8. Akerbeltz are expensive four-point commanders. Native Astral, Death, Water, and Glamour are absent. Air begins at A2, which is useful but does not by itself cast every famous Air spell or the national A3 ritual.

## Pyrène evidence and ruleset

The official revision-2 manual supplies the roster, national summary, and Send Aatxe. The pinned 6.35 Inspector export resolves randoms:

- Pyrènian Bishop: B1 H2 plus one guaranteed Fire, Earth, or Blood level;
- Pyrènian Monk: H1 plus one guaranteed Fire, Earth, Nature, or Blood level;
- Sorgina: fixed F1 A2 B2;
- Akerbeltz: E1 N2 B3, one guaranteed Earth, Nature, or Blood level, plus an independent 10% second roll from the same set.

These are unmodded records. Dominions Enhanced and Divinitus must be treated as separate rosters.

## Pyrène conversion chain

```
resistant infantry, crossbows, and cavalry
-> forests and caves secured during expansion
-> distributed commanders and blood hunters
-> Akerbeltz crossbreeding and Nature-Earth support
-> Sorgina Air-Blood battlefield groups
-> slave economy, blood rituals, and remote pressure
-> mobile sacred and supernatural armies
```

Pyrène can own many commanders while still lacking the right package. Distributed recruitment only becomes an advantage when every location has a declared job and the roads, laboratories, and blood-slave routes connect them.

## National body and terrain rules

The ordinary Pyrènian and Bekryde roster has partial resistance to Fire and Cold, darkvision, and broad Mountain Survival. Those traits matter most when the nation deliberately chooses terrain and opponents that make them relevant. Five points of resistance softens common elemental damage; it is not immunity to concentrated battlefield magic.

| Geographic asset               | What it can produce                  | Strategic use                                                                   |
|--------------------------------|--------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Forest without a fort          | Akerbeltz                            | Expensive high Blood-Nature-Earth mage production outside the normal fort queue |
| Cave without a fort            | Bekryde troops, scout, and leader    | Cheap local bodies, information, and mountain-capable reinforcement             |
| Any suitable non-fort province | Pyrènian Monk                        | Distributed H1 and one random path from F/E/N/B                                 |
| Capital                        | Emerald sacred cavalry and Akerbeltz | Sacred shock force and the most reliable elite mage point                       |
| Ordinary fort                  | Main human army, Sorgina, Bishop     | Repeatable military and magic core                                              |

The extra Turmoil design limit is permission, not a command. Blood hunting, expensive commanders, forts, and knights still depend on population and gold. A high-Turmoil design needs a clear compensating engine rather than assuming national flavour makes lost income harmless.

## Pyrène roster by job

| Unit                        | Best job                                           | Important limit                                                                       |
|-----------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Bekryde and Bekryde Warrior | Cheap cave and mountain-capable line or siege mass | Low MR and light armour; local availability controls scale                            |
| Pyrènian Crossbowman        | Armour pressure behind a screen                    | Precision 8 and ordinary protection                                                   |
| Pyrènian Spearman           | Shielded line and general frontage                 | Ordinary damage and MR 9                                                              |
| Pyrènian Footman            | Higher-Defence shielded line                       | Armour and Encumbrance can become a fatigue problem                                   |
| Pyrènian Swordsman          | High-damage heavy infantry                         | No shield and modest Defence                                                          |
| Pyrènian Man at Arms        | Better-quality line                                | Higher gold, resources, and recruitment points                                        |
| Pyrènian Knight             | Mobile shock and reserve                           | Expensive and still MR 9 on the rider                                                 |
| Emerald Knight              | Capital sacred cavalry                             | Seventy gold, forty resources, thirty-one recruitment points, and capital competition |

The sacred mouflon is a separate component with strong armour, Mountain Survival, and Cold Resistance. Its low Magic Resistance remains relevant against effects that can target the mount. Book IV's mounted rules should be applied to both rider and animal.

## Pyrène commander and mage portfolio

| Commander       | Paths or ability     | Main jobs                                                | Recruitment warning                               |
|-----------------|----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| Pyrènian Bishop | B1 H2 + F/E/B random | Blood sacrifice, hunting, priest support, low-path magic | Two recruitment points; record random immediately |



| Commander                             | Paths or ability                                            | Main jobs                                                      | Recruitment warning                                                                                       |
|---------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Sorgina                               | F1 A2 B2, flying, Storm Immune                              | Blood hunting, Air and Fire battle magic, mobile reinforcement | Costs 260 gold; mass recruitment can consume the whole research and fort budget                           |
| Akerbeltz                             | E1 N2 B3 + E/N/B random, Blood Searcher 1, Cross Breeder +4 | Blood economy, Cross Breeding, Nature-Earth support, searching | 450 gold, four recruitment points; forests need protection and logistics                                  |
| Pyrènian Monk                         | H1 + F/E/N/B random, non-fort recruitment                   | Distributed research, searching, rituals, preaching            | Slow recruitment and modest research efficiency; use the roll rather than collecting them without purpose |
| Emerald Count                         | Sacred H1 cavalry leader                                    | Sacred command and mobile priest support                       | Capital-only, two recruitment points                                                                      |
| Castellan, Marquess, Bekryde Champion | Mundane leadership                                          | Main army, cavalry, and cave command                           | Pick leadership for the actual force instead of paying for unused armour or mobility                      |

## Random-path consequences

A guaranteed one-in-three Bishop random creates F1B1H2, E1B1H2, or B2H2. This gives every ordinary fort a predictable portfolio after several recruits, but it does not guarantee the required result on the first month.

The Monk's one-in-four random is valuable because recruitment is geographically distributed. F1, E1, N1, and B1 results cover searching and minor rituals without using a fort. The trade is speed: a province producing a Monk is not producing another special commander that month, and the mage still needs a laboratory for most magic work.

The Akerbeltz guaranteed random produces E2, N3, or B4 before the 10% roll is considered. Each result changes its best job:

- E2 can use Summon Earthpower to reach higher battlefield Earth thresholds;
- N3 opens stronger Nature support and searching;
- B4 accelerates high Blood rituals;
- the rare second roll may deepen or mix these roles, but no opening should require it.

## Blood economy without self-destruction

Pyrène has unusually broad access to hunters: Sorginak are B2, Bishops are at least B1, and Akerbeltz are B3 with Blood Searcher 1. That does not mean every mage should hunt.

A working blood province needs:

- enough population to survive the intended hunting period;
- hunters whose slave return exceeds their lost research or battle work;
- unrest control and patrollers;
- a laboratory or a reliable slave-transfer route;
- protection against raids and assassins;
- a declared use for the slaves.

Akerbeltz are excellent hunters but expensive researchers, ritualists, searchers, and crossbreeders. Using every one as a hunter can waste the very path breadth that makes them special. Bishops and Sorginak often provide the scalable hunting layer while selected Akerbeltz handle the difficult Blood, Nature, or Earth jobs.

Blood sacrifice should be budgeted separately. Slaves spent on dominion are not available for rituals or battle. The sacrifice is worthwhile when it changes a real dominion contest, sacred operation, or victory condition.

## Pyrène opening priorities

- 1 Test the local independent types against shielded infantry, crossbows, knights, or the Pretender.
- 2 Identify every reachable forest and cave before deciding the first fort route.
- 3 Recruit enough Sorginak and Bishops to start research and a controlled blood economy.
- 4 Use forests for Akerbeltz only when the province can be defended and connected.
- 5 Keep capital resources from being consumed by Emerald Knights when infrastructure is the actual bottleneck.

## Expansion packages to test

| Package                      | Intended target                                  | Failure signal                                                      |
|------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Shielded foot plus crossbows | Ordinary infantry and armour                     | Precision and friendly fire erase the value of the ranged line      |
| Heavy foot                   | Low-damage opponents                             | Fatigue, armour-piercing weapons, or magic overwhelms protection    |
| Pyrènian Knights             | Weak lines and exposed ranged troops             | Anti-large weapons or MR attacks trade too efficiently              |
| Emerald Knights              | Important high-value provinces                   | Capital production and resources fall behind the economic timetable |
| Awake Pretender              | Difficult early targets and fast terrain capture | The design duplicates jobs the national roster already performs     |

## Pyrène research response tree

### Trunk: establish Blood and practical equipment

Blood 1  
-> Blood 3  
-> Construction 2 or 4

Early Blood research should lead to a named slave use. Blood 3 is especially important for Cross Breeding, because Akerbeltz carry Adept Cross Breeder +4. Construction opens tools for hunters, commanders, and battlefield specialists. The exact order changes when war demands an immediate Air, Earth, or Nature spell.

### Branch A: Sorgina battlefield magic

Evocation 2 and later Air research gives the fixed A2 Sorgina a repeatable damage role. A2 is not A3. Storm, the national Send Aatxe ritual, and several famous Air breakpoints require a real route to A3 or higher. A Pretender, hero, empowerment, booster chain, or later summon must own that bridge. Storm Power can raise a mage during an existing storm; it does not solve who created the first storm.

## Branch B: Akerbeltz Earth and Nature

Conjuration 3 lets E2 Akerbeltz use Summon Earthpower and makes several elemental routes practical. Alteration and Enchantment then provide protection, armour reduction, regeneration, poison, or control according to the actual random and target. Do not research N3 or E3 packages until the matching random has been recorded or a reliable bridge exists.

## Branch C: blood battlefield and ritual pressure

Blood research should be advanced in steps attached to a current army or strategic ritual, not rushed as one uninterrupted school. The nation can support Sabbath structures through Blood, but Book V's communion correction ledger applies: master throughput, slave paths, gem use, and collapse must be budgeted. A large slave stock is not permission to use an untested communion.

## Branch D: Send Aatxe

The national ritual is Conjuration 6, A3, costs six Air gems, has range four, is anonymous, and cannot be cast underwater. Native Sorginak stop at A2. The research target therefore becomes real only after the A3 caster route is written down. If that route exists, the ritual gives Pyrène a cheap remote pressure tool; if it does not, Conjuration 6 alone delivers nothing.

# Pyrène battlefield packages

## Resistant human line

Pyrènian infantry can absorb modest Fire and Cold better than ordinary humans. Add shields, spacing, and the right troop type before adding magic. The resistance is a margin that makes some trades favourable, not a reason to stand inside full battlefield elemental damage.

## Sorgina strike group

Flying, Storm-Immune F1 A2 B2 mages can reposition rapidly and join selected battles. Their scripts should use reachable A2, F1, or Blood effects and preserve a retreat route. Flying mobility does not protect a 10-HP human body from arrows, assassins, or a collapsed screen.

## Akerbeltz crossbreeding economy

Cross Breeding converts Blood slaves and an Akerbeltz turn into variable bodies. The +4 national specialist bonus makes Pyrène unusually suited to the system, but the output remains a portfolio rather than a guaranteed army type. Record batches, costs, useful results, leadership burden, and attrition before assigning a fixed strategic value.

## Sacred mouflon force

Emerald Knights offer protection, mobility, Mountain Survival, and a sacred mount. They are scarce enough that the bless should improve survival and role reliability. The package still needs magic resistance, fatigue control, and answers to anti-large weapons. A sacred cavalry army that cannot replace losses is a finite resource.

## Pyrène Pretender families

| Family                   | What it solves                                                       | What it must not conceal                                            |
|--------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Air bridge               | A3+ for Storm, Send Aatxe, stronger Air, and battlefield transitions | The caster still needs research, gems, safety, and timing           |
| Astral or Death import   | Missing strategic paths, resistance magic, summons, and communions   | Imported access may remain tied to one irreplaceable god            |
| Scales and blood economy | Gold, forts, laboratories, population, and recovery from hunting     | Turmoil or Death choices can undermine the population base          |
| Moderate cavalry bless   | Emerald Knights and mounts                                           | Sacred production is capital and resource limited                   |
| Awake expander           | Rapid forests, caves, and chokepoints                                | National infantry and knights may already handle ordinary expansion |

The most valuable design often solves a missing system rather than adding more Fire, Nature, or Blood to paths already available. Air, Astral, Death, Water, or a specific global route can change the whole national tree.

## Pyrène matchup and failure matrix

| Enemy problem                  | First answer to examine                                                         | Avoid                                                                   |
|--------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| High-MR attacks against troops | Bufs, screening, summons, imported Astral, shorter exposure                     | Assuming armour protects MR 9 infantry                                  |
| Fire or Cold warfare           | National resistance plus additional buffs and spacing                           | Treating resistance 5 as immunity                                       |
| Heavy armour                   | Crossbows, great swords, Earth armour reduction, Blood or summoned alternatives | Relying on low-Precision crossbows without enough volume and protection |
| Fast raiders                   | Flying Sorgina reserve, cave and forest scouts, local commanders                | Leaving blood provinces and forest mages undefended                     |
| Battlefield-wide Air           | Storm immunity on Sorginak, shock resistance plans, dispersed command           | Extending a mage's immunity to the whole army                           |
| Population pressure            | Rotate hunting, control unrest, move the blood centre                           | Continuing to hunt a province after its long-term value collapses       |

## Monthly Pyrène audit

- Which forests and caves are producing something that no ordinary fort can?
- Are blood hunters separated from battle mages and researchers?
- What are the current slave income, stock, and committed uses?
- Are Bishop, Monk, and Akerbeltz randoms recorded?
- Does the active research target have a real caster?
- Who reaches A3 for Storm or Send Aatxe?
- Is the sacred cavalry queue delaying forts or mages?
- Are MR 9 troops being sent into a counter they cannot armour through?
- Can every distributed recruitment province be reinforced or evacuated?

## Pyrène verification ledger

The next useful tests are:

- 1 expansion ranges for shielded foot, crossbows, Pyrènian Knights, and Emerald Knights;
- 2 current live confirmation of Bishop, Monk, and Akerbeltz random displays;
- 3 Blood Searcher 1 returns across population and unrest bands;
- 4 Cross Breeder +4 outcome records across a versioned sample;
- 5 Air transition packages before and after a real A3 bridge;
- 6 sacred rider and mouflon survival under MR and anti-large attacks;
- 7 distributed-recruitment payback from forests and caves;
- 8 DE and Divinitus variants kept separate from this unmodded dossier.

## Dossier source register

### Official

- Dominions 6 Manual, revision 2: MA Marignon and MA Pyrène nation pages, national spells and rituals, research, communions, Blood, Inquisition, mounts, and fort construction.
- Illwinter official patch history through 6.36, including the current Send Aatxe restriction and communion corrections.

### Structured snapshot

- Dominions 6 Data Inspector, commit cfac4311bc0b58053b8dead7bfffbc036ba9bd5dc, pinned to the 6.35 data update; used for mage random masks and current object cross-checks.

### Interpretation boundary

Roster entries, path masks, costs, and national ritual requirements are source facts. Openings, research trees, Pretender families, battlefield packages, and matchup advice are strategy. Expansion counts, random-result timing, Blood returns, and crossbreeding outputs remain test questions until a versioned raw set is published.